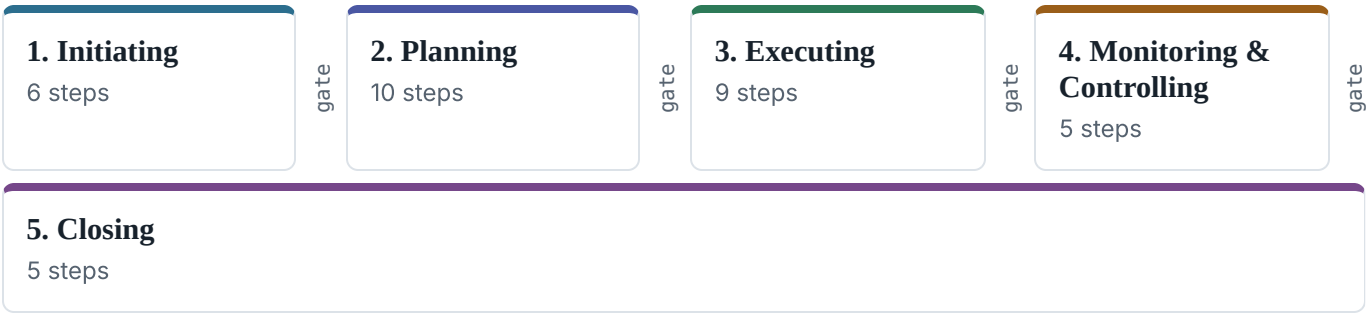
A PLAYBOOK FOR HYBRID, AGILE AND TECHNICAL PROJECTS

Project Manager in a Box

Every step of managing a project, from the first request to the final retrospective, with the inputs, outputs, owners and ready-to-use templates for each one.

Author **James Pearson** Version **0.3 (prototype)** Released **November 2026**

Latest version **on GitHub** License **CC BY-NC-SA 4.0**



35 steps · 28 templates · 1 project workbook with a live dashboard

Contents

About this playbook

How to use it

Tailoring: Small, Medium, Large

Roles

Project repository

The Project Workbook

1. Initiating

- 1.1 Capture the request and build the business case
- 1.2 Define goals and success criteria
- 1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders
- 1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook
- 1.5 Draft and approve the project charter
- 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff

2. Planning

- 2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements
- 2.2 Define scope and build the feature list
- 2.3 Build the release plan
- 2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget
- 2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI
- 2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses
- 2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement
- 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance
- 2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement
- 2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate

3. Executing

- 3.1 Acquire and onboard the team
- 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence
- 3.3 Assure quality
- 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate
- 3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues
- 3.6 Manage vendors and contracts
- 3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions
- 3.8 Refine the backlog
- 3.9 Release an increment

4. Monitoring & Controlling

- 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality
- 4.2 Control changes
- 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement
- 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables
- 4.5 Report status and escalate

5. Closing

- 5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations
- 5.2 Close contracts and finances
- 5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned
- 5.4 Write the closeout and impact report
- 5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

A. Template library

B. Agile quick reference

C. Glossary

D. Sources & further reading

E. Recovery plays by cause

F. License & credits

How to use this playbook

Use it in one of two ways. Follow it front to back as a project manager in a box, or dip into a single step to fill a gap in the way you already work.

Run a project with it

Start at Chapter 1 and work through each step in order. Every step tells you what to do, what you need, what you produce, where to keep it, who owns it and which template to use. Download the Project Workbook for your track first. Most templates are already built into it as tabs.

Fill a gap

Use the contents to jump straight to a step, such as change control or a status report. Each step stands on its own, and each template has its own guide in Appendix A.

CHOOSE YOUR TRACK

Every step has one shared core plus the guidance for your track. This copy shows the Agile track, with the Technical guidance. The web playbook switches between the tracks, and the other track has its own PDF.

AGILE TRACK

For projects that run entirely in sprints from a product backlog, with a named Product Owner, inside three limits set before work starts: a start and end date, a budget, and an out-of-scope statement. Inside those limits, what gets built is decided sprint by sprint.

- The solution will be shaped by user feedback as you go
- The date and budget are fixed, but there is no fixed specification
- One person can act as Product Owner, with the time and authority to order the backlog
- Little plan-driven work, such as long procurement, construction or regulatory phases, that must run on its own fixed plan

HYBRID TRACK

For projects that mix plan-driven work (fixed milestones, budgets, procurement, compliance) with iterative work (sprints, backlogs, frequent feedback). It is typical of business, operations, marketing and nonprofit programs, and of any project where some workstreams are predictable and others are not. Choose Hybrid over Agile when some of the work has to follow a fixed plan of its own.

- Fixed date or funding cycle, but the solution will change as you learn
- Mix of technical and non-technical workstreams
- Stakeholders need a milestone plan; the team prefers to work in sprints

TECHNICAL TRACK (IT + SECURITY)

For software, infrastructure, cloud, data and cybersecurity projects. It adds the gates technical work needs: architecture and security review, environments, test strategy, change advisory board (CAB) approval, cut-over and rollback, compliance evidence and handover to operations.

- Changes production systems, data or access
- Has security, privacy or regulatory obligations (e.g., PII, SOC 2, HIPAA, PCI DSS)
- Needs environments, deployments, cut-over or a rollback plan

Choose one approach, Agile or Hybrid, with the Track buttons at the top of the page. Then switch Technical on if the project changes production systems, data or access. On the Agile track the whole project runs in sprints, inside three limits set before it starts. On the Hybrid track, sprints run inside a plan with fixed milestones. The Technical track adds the gates and checks technical work needs, on either approach. The choice changes the text of the steps, the templates you are offered and the workbook you download. The two PDFs are printed with Technical on.

HOW EACH STEP IS LAID OUT

Each step has: **What it is**, **Why it matters**, **Inputs** (where to get them and who is responsible), **Outputs** (where they are kept and who is responsible), **Templates** (with download and guide), **How to do it**, **Track guidance** and **Done when**. Gates between phases are the formal checkpoints where the sponsor decides whether the project goes on.

Terms of art follow the PMBOK® Guide 8th Edition. PMI, PMBOK and PMP are registered marks of the Project Management Institute, Inc. This playbook is independent and is not affiliated with or endorsed by PMI.

Tailoring: Small, Medium, Large

Scale the process to the project. Pick a size in Step 1.4 and use this table to decide how much rigor each area needs. Record what you skip in Template T04.

AREA	SMALL	MEDIUM	LARGE
Typical profile	< 3 months, < 5 people, one team, low risk	3–9 months, 5–20 people, a few teams or one vendor	> 9 months, multiple teams or vendors, regulated or high risk
Charter	One-page charter, approved by email	Full charter, sponsor sign-off	Full charter + business case, steering-committee approval
Schedule	Start and end date; sprint calendar	Release plan with sprint and release dates	Release plan across teams, with the dependencies between teams
Risk	Top-5 risks in the RAID log	Scored RAID log, reviewed bi-weekly	Risk management plan, quantitative analysis, weekly review
Change control	Agile PM and sponsor agree changes to a limit by email	Change log; change request when a limit moves	Formal approval board for changes to a limit
Reporting	Email update after each sprint	Status report after each sprint + dashboard	Status report after each sprint + monthly steering pack + gate reviews
Closing	30-minute retro + handover note	Retro, closeout report, transition sign-off	Full closeout, impact report, contract closure, audit archive

Roles

The ‘Responsible’ columns in every step use these roles. On a small project one person may hold several.

This playbook calls the role the Agile Project Manager (Agile PM). Organizations also use titles such as Delivery Manager, Delivery Lead or Scrum Master, and on some

projects one person does both jobs. When the Agile Project Manager also acts as Scrum Master, they take on the Scrum Master's accountabilities as the Scrum Guide describes them. In Agile view, "PM" in the steps means the Agile Project Manager.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO
Sponsor	Senior leader who owns the business case, funds the project, sets the three limits and approves any change to them, and makes go/no-go calls at each gate.
Agile Project Manager (Agile PM)	Leads the project inside its three limits: enables the team, removes roadblocks, watches the forecast against the end date, and owns risks and reporting. Accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and gates where the RACI says so.
Product Owner (PO)	One person, not a committee. Accountable for the product goal and for ordering the backlog; speaks for users and accepts or rejects finished work. Required on the Agile track.
Scrum Master	Accountable for the team's effectiveness: coaches the way of working and helps remove impediments. Often the Agile PM.
Developers	The people who build, test and deliver each increment, including vendor staff. They plan each sprint and decide how the work is done.
Business Analyst (BA)	Helps the Product Owner write and refine requirements and backlog items, and checks that the solution meets business needs.
Technical Lead	Owns the solution design, engineering quality and technical risk, working with the Developers.
Security Lead	Owns security and privacy requirements, threat models, control evidence and sign-off for go-live (Technical track).
Functional Managers	Line managers who supply people to the project and agree to their availability.
Finance Partner	Validates estimates, releases funds, tracks spend against the sprints delivered.
Procurement / Vendor Manager	Runs sourcing, contracts and vendor performance.

ROLE	WHAT THEY DO
Change Control Board (CCB) / Change Advisory Board (CAB)	The group that approves changes to a limit, where the charter names one (CCB), or changes to production systems (CAB).
Operations / Support Owner	Receives the finished product and runs it after go-live.

The Product Owner is accountable for the why, what and when, mainly through the order of the backlog. The Developers decide how the work is done. The Agile Project Manager is responsible for the conditions that let them deliver on time: enabling the team, removing roadblocks, and watching the forecast against the end date.

Who is accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and the gates varies by project: the Agile PM, the Product Owner or the sponsor. The RACI (T10) names one accountable person for each. Risks and reporting belong to the Agile PM; the backlog belongs to the Product Owner.

Project repository

Every output has a home. Set up this folder structure (in SharePoint, Google Drive, Confluence or a shared drive) on day one. The ‘Where it is kept’ column in every step refers to it.

FOLDER / FILE	CONTENTS
`00-Admin`	Charter, approvals, gate decisions, contacts
`01-Initiating`	Intake, business case, stakeholder register, approach worksheet
`02-Planning`	Requirements and features, scope statement, release plan, budget, plans (risk, comms, quality, sourcing)
`03-Executing`	Meeting notes, deliverables, test evidence, vendor documents
`04-Monitoring`	Status reports, change requests, RAID log snapshots, dashboards
`05-Closing`	Acceptance, transition, lessons learned, closeout and impact reports
`Project-Workbook-Agile.xlsx`	The live tracker: release plan, requirements and features, backlog and sprints, RAID, budget, changes, decisions, acceptance, environment, dashboard

The Project Workbook

A fill-in-ready Excel tracker that runs the project alongside this playbook. There is one for each track. Fill in the Setup tab, add your work and risks, and the Dashboard and Status Report build themselves.

Blank workbook

20 tabs: Dashboard, Status Report, Setup, Release Plan (sprints, releases and a Gantt), Requirements (with features), Backlog, Sprint Backlog, Sprint Log, Acceptance, RAID, Budget, Stakeholders, RACI, Comms, Changes, Decisions, Environment and Lessons, plus a Start Here guide and editable dropdown lists.

Download XLSX

Worked example: Project Beacon

The Agile workbook filled in for the same fictional project, Project Beacon, retold on the Agile track: seven sprints, two releases, closed out on June 22, 2026.

Download XLSX

WHAT THE DASHBOARD TELLS YOU

- **Overall health**: the worst of the schedule, budget and risk ratings. The schedule rating comes from the forecast finish against the end date, with the margin you set in Setup. You can override it.
- **The forecast**: sprints left at current velocity and the forecast finish date, next to scope done and releases accepted.
- **Insights**: one auto-written sentence per area that you can paste straight into an update.
- **Next releases and events, and the top five risks**, ranked automatically, plus the velocity and burn-up charts.

Files: 03-Project-Workbook/Project-Workbook-Agile.xlsx; 05-Examples/Project-Workbook-Agile-EXAMPLE-Project-Beacon.xlsx

CHAPTER 1 · 6 STEPS

Initiating

Decide whether the project should exist, and authorize it.

Initiating turns an idea or request into an authorized project. The goal is not a detailed plan. It is shared agreement on why the work matters, what success looks like, who is involved and how the work will broadly be delivered. Most failed projects can be traced back to a skipped or rushed Initiating phase: unclear goals, a missing sponsor or stakeholders who never agreed on scope.

Exit gate Initiation gate: the sponsor approves the charter, the Agile PM and the Product Owner are named, and funding for planning is released.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Initiate Project or Phase; Identify Stakeholders (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

1.2 Define goals and success criteria

1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders

1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

1.5 Draft and approve the project charter

1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff

1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

WHAT IT IS

Turn the incoming request into a short, structured description of the problem, the opportunity, the options and the expected value. This is the business case: the argument that the project is worth doing at all.

WHY IT MATTERS

It stops projects that should never start, and it gives every later decision (scope, budget, trade-offs) something to anchor to. When people argue about scope later, the business case decides.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Request, idea or mandate	Email, intake form, strategy document or leadership meeting	Requester / Sponsor
Strategic goals or OKRs	Annual plan, strategy deck, OKR tracker	Sponsor / Leadership
Historical data and lessons from similar projects	PMO lessons library, past closeout reports	PMO / PM
Rough cost and benefit figures	Finance partner, vendor quotes, operational metrics	Finance Partner

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Intake & Business Case (approved or rejected)	Repository: 01-Initiating	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)
Go/no-go decision	Decision Log (workbook) and 00-Admin	Sponsor

TEMPLATES

T01 Project Intake & Business Case Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T01-Project-Intake-Business-Case.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Meet the requester and ask the ‘5 Ws’: what, why, who benefits, when and where.
2. Ask three stakeholders from different areas to describe the problem, then combine their answers into one problem statement.
3. Quantify the cost of doing nothing and the expected benefit.
4. Compare at least two options, including doing nothing, and recommend one.
5. Present to the sponsor and record the decision.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Show which parts of the value can be delivered early (for example a pilot or MVP) and what fixed date or event the project has to meet. That date becomes one of the three limits in Step 1.5.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add an early view of the technical options (build, buy, configure, SaaS), the systems affected, data sensitivity (public, internal, confidential, regulated) and any obvious security or compliance triggers.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Problem and benefits are quantified
- ✓ Options compared
- ✓ Sponsor decision recorded

1.2 Define goals and success criteria

WHAT IT IS

Write measurable goals (SMART goals or OKRs), a product goal, and the criteria the sponsor will use to judge the project a success, covering both project success (by the end date, within the budget, inside the out-of-scope statement) and product success (adoption, savings, risk reduced).

WHY IT MATTERS

Measurable goals make trade-offs objective and keep everyone aiming at the same target. Without them, ‘done’ becomes a matter of opinion and closeout becomes a negotiation.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Approved business case	01-Initiating	Sponsor
Organizational OKRs and KPIs	Strategy or OKR tracker	Leadership
Baseline metrics (today’s numbers)	Operational reports, analytics, finance	Business owner / BA

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Goals, product goal and success criteria	Charter section 2 and the workbook Setup tab	PM and Product Owner (authors), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T02 Project Charter Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Draft 2–4 goals using SMART (Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant, Time-bound).
2. Write the product goal with the Product Owner: one or two sentences on the future state of the product that the backlog serves, for example “Volunteers and donors manage their own relationship with the pantry online”. The Product Owner is accountable for it and keeps it visible.
3. For each goal, record the baseline value, the target value and the data source.
4. Separate project success criteria from product or benefit success criteria.
5. Agree with the sponsor how and when the benefits will be measured. Some benefits arrive after closeout.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Each sprint will also have a one-sentence sprint goal that moves the product toward the product goal (Step 3.2). Add interim goals where they help, for example ‘pilot used by 20 volunteers by week 6’.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include non-functional targets: availability (e.g., 99.9%), performance, recovery time objective (RTO) and recovery point objective (RPO), and security outcomes (e.g., ‘MFA enforced for 100% of admin accounts’).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every goal has a baseline, a target and a data source
- ✓ Sponsor agrees how success will be measured
- ✓ Product goal agreed with the sponsor and the Product Owner

1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders

WHAT IT IS

List everyone who can affect, or is affected by, the project. Assess their power, their interest and their current versus desired level of support.

WHY IT MATTERS

Stakeholders who are missed become late requirements, blockers or opponents. Early analysis tells you where to spend your relationship time.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case and charter draft	01-Initiating	PM
Organization charts	HR system / intranet	Functional managers
Sponsor and team knowledge	Interviews	Sponsor / PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Stakeholder Register with power/interest grid	Workbook: Stakeholders tab	PM
Environment Log started (insights about the wider environment around the project)	Workbook: Environment tab	PM

TEMPLATES

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

T28 Environment Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx; 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Brainstorm stakeholders with the sponsor and work through each group: users, managers, IT, finance, legal, vendors, regulators and partners.

2. Interview key stakeholders: priorities, concerns, preferred role, preferred communication.
3. Name the Product Owner: one person, with the time and authority to order the backlog and accept finished work. If no one can take the role, the project is not ready for the Agile track. Find the person first, or choose the Hybrid track.
4. Score Power and Interest 1–5 and place each person on the grid.
5. Plan an engagement action for anyone whose current support is below the level you need.
6. Start the Environment Log (T28) and note what is happening in the environment around the project that you should be aware of, such as a reorganization, a funding cycle, a regulatory date, or an initiative being taken up by other project teams that may influence or inspire this project. Project value does not exist in a vacuum. This log is for insights, not risks.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The Product Owner is one person, not a committee. Stakeholders' requests reach the backlog through them.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include the Security, Privacy, Infrastructure and Operations owners, the Change Advisory Board (CAB), and any auditor or compliance contact.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Register complete
- ✓ Every high-power stakeholder has an engagement action
- ✓ Product Owner named and confirmed
- ✓ Environment Log started

1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

WHAT IT IS

Choose the track for the project, Agile or Hybrid, decide whether the Technical track applies, and decide how much of this playbook the project needs (Small, Medium or Large).

WHY IT MATTERS

The approach drives everything that follows: how you plan, report and handle change. Tailoring keeps the process proportionate, because too much process slows small projects down and too little sinks large ones.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case and goals	01-Initiating	PM
Organizational standards or PMO methodology	PMO / intranet	PMO
Team experience and constraints	Functional managers, Tech Lead	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Approach & Tailoring Worksheet	Repository: 01-Initiating	PM

TEMPLATES

T04 Delivery Approach & Tailoring Worksheet Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T04-Delivery-Approach-Tailoring-Worksheet.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Score each workstream on the suitability questions in T04 (requirement stability, feedback availability, cost of change, regulation and so on).
2. Choose Agile when every workstream scores agile and the project can work inside three limits with a named Product Owner. Otherwise choose Hybrid.
3. Switch on Technical if the project changes production systems, data or access, or has security, privacy or regulatory obligations.
4. Pick the project size using the tailoring table in ‘How to use this playbook’.
5. Record what you will skip or simplify and why.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

On the Agile track every workstream runs in sprints, inside the three limits: the end date, the budget and the out-of-scope statement.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Regulated or production-impacting work usually keeps formal gates (architecture review, security review, CAB) even when the build happens in sprints.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Track chosen (Agile or Hybrid, with Technical yes or no)
- ✓ Size and tailoring decisions recorded

1.5 Draft and approve the project charter

WHAT IT IS

Write the charter: the short document that formally authorizes the project, names the Agile PM and the Product Owner, and sets the product goal, the outcomes, the three limits, the risks and the governance.

WHY IT MATTERS

The charter gives the PM authority and gives everyone a single reference point. Under PMI's approach it is the formal start of the project.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Business case, goals, stakeholder register, approach worksheet	01-Initiating	PM
High-level budget and funding source	Finance Partner	Finance Partner / Sponsor
Known constraints and assumptions	Sponsor, SMEs	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Signed Project Charter	Repository: 00-Admin; summary in the workbook Setup tab	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T02 Project Charter Download DOCX Example DOCX

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Fill in T02 using the earlier outputs. Don’t rewrite what is already approved.
2. Write the scope as the product goal, the outcomes and a first ordered feature list, and write an explicit out-of-scope statement: what the project will not include, however the backlog changes later.
3. Set the three limits: the start and end date (and the event it is tied to, if any), the budget, and the out-of-scope statement. These are the project’s baselines (Step 2.10).
4. Name the Agile PM and state their decision rights in time and money (for example, can approve costs up to $1,000 from the reserve). Backlog order is the Product Owner’s decision, so it is not part of the Agile PM’s authority.
5. Say who is accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and each gate, and record it in the RACI (T10).
6. Review the draft with key stakeholders, resolve comments, then get the sponsor’s signature.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The backlog can change freely inside the three limits. Only a change to a limit, or a cost above the Agile PM’s authority, needs approval (Step 4.2).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add the systems in scope, data classification, the required review gates (architecture, security, CAB) and the target environments.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Charter signed
- ✓ Three limits stated
- ✓ Agile PM authority stated
- ✓ Out-of-scope statement agreed

1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff

WHAT IT IS

Run a short gate review to confirm that Initiating is complete, then hold a kickoff meeting with the core team and key stakeholders to launch Planning.

WHY IT MATTERS

The gate makes sure the project is ready to move on. The kickoff builds shared understanding and momentum, and gives the team a chance to raise concerns early, when changes are still cheap.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Signed charter, stakeholder register	00-Admin, workbook	PM
Team availability	Functional managers	Functional managers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Gate decision	Decision Log	Sponsor
Kickoff notes and action items	03-Executing/Meetings; actions in the workbook	PM

TEMPLATES

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit Download DOCX

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run the gate checklist: charter signed, sponsor engaged, funding confirmed for Planning.
2. Send the kickoff pre-read 48 hours ahead.
3. At kickoff, cover the why (sponsor), the product goal, the out-of-scope statement, the release plan, roles (RACI), ways of working and next steps.
4. Send notes and actions within 24 hours.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The person the RACI names runs the gate. At kickoff, agree the team's working agreement: sprint length, the sprint events (Appendix B.1) and how the forecast will be reported.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Confirm access, tools and environments needed in the first two weeks (repositories, ticketing, cloud accounts, test data).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Gate passed
- ✓ Kickoff held
- ✓ Actions logged

CHAPTER 2 · 10 STEPS

Planning

Work out how the work will get done, and set the baselines you will measure against.

Planning turns the charter into a plan the team can start sprinting from: the product vision and feature list (scope), the release plan (schedule), the budget, the team, the risks, how people will be kept informed and how quality will be assured. The baselines on the Agile track are the three limits: the end date, the budget and the out-of-scope statement. Plan the first sprints in detail and add detail to the rest of the backlog as the project goes (rolling-wave planning).

Exit gate Planning gate: the sponsor approves the three limits, the product goal and the release plan; the team is ready to start sprinting.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Integrate and Align Project Plans; Plan Sourcing Strategy; Plan Scope Management; Elicit and Analyze Requirements; Define Scope; Develop Scope Structure; Plan Schedule Management; Develop Schedule; Plan Financial Management; Estimate Costs; Develop Budget; Plan Stakeholder Engagement; Plan Communications Management; Plan Resource Management; Estimate Resources; Plan Risk Management; Identify Risks; Perform Risk Analysis; Plan Risk Responses (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements

2.2 Define scope and build the feature list

2.3 Build the release plan

2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget

2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI

2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses

2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement

2.8 Plan quality and acceptance

2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement

2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate

2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements

WHAT IT IS

Find out from stakeholders what the solution must do and how well, group the requirements into features, and record both in the Requirements Register. The work that delivers each requirement goes in the Backlog as backlog items.

WHY IT MATTERS

Requirements are the bridge between the business goal and the deliverables. Most rework comes from requirements that were missing, vague or never agreed.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Charter, goals, stakeholder register	00-Admin, workbook	PM
Current process documents, user feedback, support tickets	Business owners, service desk	BA / PO
Policies and regulations	Legal, Compliance, Security	Compliance / Security Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements Register, with features	Workbook: Requirements tab	Product Owner with the BA
Product Backlog	Workbook: Backlog tab (or the team's backlog tool)	Product Owner

TEMPLATES

T06 Requirements Register Download XLSX

T25 Backlog Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose methods: interviews, workshops, observation, surveys, document review, prototyping.

2. Write each requirement as a user story (‘As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit]’) or a clear ‘shall’ statement, with acceptance criteria. The story describes the value the requirement promises.
3. Group the requirements into features. A feature is a capability users will recognize, such as “Shift booking”. Give each feature an ID (F-01) and record it against its requirements in the Requirements Register (T06). Several requirements can share one feature.
4. Prioritize with MoSCoW together with the sponsor and the PO. The PO’s order in the Backlog then decides what is built first.
5. Trace each requirement to a goal or to the product goal, so anything that serves neither is challenged.
6. Have a named person approve each requirement before it is built, and record who approved it. Later, record who accepted it as delivered.
7. Break each requirement into backlog items (T25) and link each item to it. Every requirement needs at least one item, including a non-functional one that is checked through the Definition of Done, so that it is accepted at a sprint review like any other.
8. Detail only what the next one or two sprints need. The rest is refined as the project goes (Step 3.8).

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Requirements change as you learn. Adding, removing or reordering them inside the out-of-scope statement is normal Product Owner work, not a change (Step 4.2).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Capture non-functional requirements explicitly: security, privacy, accessibility (WCAG 2.2 AA), performance, availability, logging, data retention and integration interfaces.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Features named
- ✓ Musts for the first release have acceptance criteria
- ✓ Every requirement has at least one backlog item
- ✓ Priorities agreed with the PO and sponsor
- ✓ NFRs captured
- ✓ Every Must has a named approver

2.2 Define scope and build the feature list

WHAT IT IS

Turn the requirements into a short product vision and an out-of-scope statement, and lay out the features as a feature list or story map (Appendix B.4).

WHY IT MATTERS

On the Agile track the feature list and the out-of-scope statement are the scope. They show what the product will be and where its edges are, without fixing the detail too early.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements register	Workbook: Requirements	BA / PO
Charter scope and exclusions	00-Admin	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Scope Statement (product vision and out-of-scope statement)	Repository: 02-Planning	Product Owner and PM (authors), Sponsor (approver)
Feature list or story map	Workbook: Requirements tab (Feature column); story map in 02-Planning	Product Owner with the team

TEMPLATES

T07 Scope Statement Download DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T07-Scope-Statement-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Write the Scope Statement (T07) as the product vision: who the product is for, the problem it solves and its main features, plus the out-of-scope statement from the charter, made specific.

2. Build a story map with the Product Owner and the Developers: user activities from left to right, the stories under each, and lines that slice it into releases (Appendix B.4).
3. Check that every requirement in the register belongs to a feature, and mark which release slice each feature falls in.
4. Record the constraints and assumptions; copy the assumptions into the RAID log.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

There is no WBS on the Agile track. The feature list shows the shape of the product, and the backlog holds the detail.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include the work people often forget: environments, CI/CD pipeline, data migration, security testing, documentation, runbooks, training, cut-over and hypercare.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Product vision and out-of-scope statement signed
- ✓ Every requirement belongs to a feature
- ✓ First release slice agreed

2.3 Build the release plan

WHAT IT IS

Set the sprint calendar between the start and end dates, place the releases and fixed events on it, and forecast from velocity how much of the backlog fits.

WHY IT MATTERS

The release plan turns the end date into sprints the team can plan against, and the forecast shows early whether the work that matters most will fit.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Feature list and Backlog	Workbook: Requirements and Backlog tabs	Product Owner
Resource availability and calendars	Functional managers, team	Functional managers
Sizes from the Developers	Sizing session	Developers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Release Plan with sprints, releases and fixed events	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM with the Product Owner

TEMPLATES

T08 Release Plan Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T08-Release-Plan-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Choose the sprint length (usually two weeks) and lay out the sprints from the start date to the end date in the Release Plan (T08).
2. Add the releases and the fixed events: gates, deadlines, CAB dates. Place milestones at sprint ends where you can, so each one has a sprint review behind it.
3. Size the backlog with the Developers, in relative units (Appendix B.5).
4. Forecast what fits: sprints available times the velocity range. Before any sprint has finished, plan with a range, and replace it with real velocity after the second or third sprint.
5. Leave a visible buffer between the team’s forecast and any date promised outside the team.
6. Agree the release plan with the Product Owner and the sponsor. The start and end dates are the baseline; sprint and release dates inside them can move.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The Agile track has no activities, critical path, PERT or float. The forecast replaces them, and it is redone after every sprint (Step 4.1).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Place review gates (architecture, security, CAB) and change freeze windows in the release plan. They are fixed points the sprints have to fit around.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Sprints laid out to the end date
- ✓ Releases and fixed events placed
- ✓ First forecast made
- ✓ Developers agree the first sprints are realistic

2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget

WHAT IT IS

Estimate the cost of the team's capacity and of the fixed items (vendors, software, hardware, travel), add reserves and set the budget, which is one of the three limits.

WHY IT MATTERS

Funding approval depends on a credible estimate, and you can't control costs without a baseline to compare actual spend against.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Release plan	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM
Labor rates and cost policies	Finance / HR	Finance Partner
Vendor quotes and license prices	Procurement, vendors	Procurement

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Budget and cost baseline	Workbook: Budget tab	PM (owner), Finance Partner (validator)

TEMPLATES

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Cost the team: the cost of one sprint (people times hours times rate, or a vendor's price per sprint) times the number of sprints in the release plan.
2. Add the fixed costs: licences, tools, external tests, training.
3. Add a contingency reserve for identified risks and get management to agree a reserve for unknowns.
4. Phase the spend by sprint or month.
5. Have the Finance Partner validate it, then get the sponsor's approval. The approved budget is a limit: moving it needs a change request (Step 4.2).

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Because cost follows capacity, the budget also caps the number of sprints. When the forecast needs more sprints than the budget funds, the scope gives way first (Appendix B.5).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include cloud consumption, license tiers, security tools, penetration testing, extra environments, and ongoing run costs after go-live (total cost of ownership).

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Budget validated by Finance
- ✓ Reserves shown separately
- ✓ Budget approved as a limit

2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI

WHAT IT IS

Decide who you need, when and for how much of their time, and make clear who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable and decision.

WHY IT MATTERS

Unclear ownership is one of the most common causes of delay. A RACI turns 'I thought you were doing it' into an agreed fact.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Release plan	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM
Staff availability and skills	Functional managers	Functional managers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
RACI matrix	Workbook: RACI tab	PM
Resource commitments	Email or written agreement in 00-Admin	Functional managers

TEMPLATES

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. List the roles needed and the percentage of each person's time, by month.
2. Plan people at about 60 to 80% of their available project time, after subtracting meetings and leave (a common focus factor in agile capacity planning; a rule of thumb, not a standard). Support work and surprises take the rest, and waiting and delays grow sharply as a team nears full load, so a plan that fills everyone's week leaves no room to recover. If the plan needs more than people can give, change it now: move work, add people or cut scope. Cross-train so that no task depends on one person, and plan around known leave.
3. Get managers to commit those people in writing.
4. Build the RACI (T10) with the Agile roles and exactly one Accountable per row. Name who is accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and each gate. On the Agile track this varies by project: the Agile PM, the Product Owner or the sponsor.
5. Keep the ready-made rows: backlog order (Product Owner A), delivery toward the end date (Product Owner A, Agile PM R), how the work is done (Developers A).
6. Review it with the team and resolve any disputes over who owns what.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

If the Agile PM also acts as Scrum Master, say so in the RACI. Keep the Product Owner a different person (Appendix B.2).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Assign named owners for the architecture, security, data, environments, releases and on-call support.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every row has one A
- ✓ Budget, stakeholders, vendors and gates each have a named A
- ✓ Resource commitments in writing

2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses

WHAT IT IS

Find the risks to the project, score their probability and impact, and decide a response for each significant one. Record assumptions and dependencies at the same time.

WHY IT MATTERS

Risks you plan for are cheaper than surprises. A visible risk log also builds sponsor confidence and justifies the contingency reserves.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Charter, scope, schedule, budget	Workbook / 02-Planning	PM
Lessons from past projects	PMO lessons library	PMO
Expert input	Risk workshop with the team and SMEs	Team / SMEs

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID Log	Workbook: RAID tab	PM (owner); each item has a named owner

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run a risk workshop. Go category by category: scope, schedule, cost, people, technology, vendors, compliance, change adoption.
2. Write each risk as 'Because of <cause>, <event> may occur, leading to <impact>'.
3. Before scoring, agree what the numbers mean on this project. A scale that suits a three-month internal project will mislead a nine-month one. Five levels is a common choice, not a requirement. The example scale below is for a Medium project. Write your own limits in days and money, keep them with the RAID log, and use them every time so everyone scores the same way.
4. Score probability and impact from 1 to 5. Anything scoring 12 or more is Red and 6–11 is Amber.
5. Choose a response (avoid, mitigate, transfer, accept) with an owner and a due date.
6. Copy the assumptions from the scope statement and the external dependencies into the same log.

EXAMPLE RISK SCALE FOR A MEDIUM PROJECT

SCORE	PROBABILITY	IMPACT
1	Would surprise the team	Absorbed within a normal week
2	Could happen, but not expected	A few days' slip, or a small cost the team can cover
3	About as likely as not	About a week's slip, or a cost the sponsor should hear about
4	More likely than not	Puts a milestone or the contingency reserve at risk
5	Expected to happen	Puts the project's goal or go-live at risk

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Review the risks at every sprint review. The demos often reveal new ones.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Run a threat model (e.g., STRIDE) for new systems and record security risks in the RAID log with the Security Lead as owner. Include vendor and third-party risk.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Top risks scored
- ✓ Every Red/Amber risk has an owner and response
- ✓ Assumptions logged

2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement

WHAT IT IS

Decide who needs what information, when, in what format and from whom. Plan how to move each key stakeholder from their current to their desired level of engagement.

WHY IT MATTERS

Many project failures are communication failures. A plan makes communication routine instead of reactive and builds trust with stakeholders.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Stakeholder register	Workbook: Stakeholders	PM
Stakeholder preferences	Stakeholder interviews	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Communication Plan	Workbook: Comms tab	PM
Recurring meetings on the calendar	Team calendar	PM

TEMPLATES

- T12 Communication Plan Download XLSX
- T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx; 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Create one row per audience: sponsor, steering committee, team, end users, IT operations and so on.

2. Set the purpose, content, channel, frequency and owner for each.
3. Book recurring meetings now: the sprint events and any steering meetings.
4. Add engagement actions for resistant or unaware stakeholders.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Invite stakeholders to sprint reviews. A live demo often does more than a written status report.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Plan release notes, maintenance-window notices, CAB submissions and incident communications.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every key stakeholder has a communication row
- ✓ Recurring meetings booked

2.8 Plan quality and acceptance

WHAT IT IS

Agree the Definition of Done, the quality standards and the test activities, and how items, requirements, features and releases will be accepted.

WHY IT MATTERS

Quality is meeting requirements and stakeholder expectations. Agreeing in advance how it will be judged avoids arguments over acceptance at the end.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Requirements and acceptance criteria	Workbook: Requirements	BA / PO
Organizational and industry standards	PMO, Compliance, Security	Quality / Compliance

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Quality & Acceptance Plan (short form, with the Definition of Done)	Repository: 02-Planning	PM / Tech Lead
Definition of Done logged as a decision	Workbook: Decisions tab	PM
Acceptance Log set up	Workbook: Acceptance tab	PM / PO

TEMPLATES

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T23 Acceptance Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. List the standards that apply.
2. Write the Definition of Done with the Developers: the checklist every item must meet. Record it as a decision in the Decision Log (T17) with a version and date, and log every later change the same way.
3. Build checks into the Definition of Done where you can (for example an automated accessibility check), so quality is checked in every item instead of being saved for the end.
4. Set up the Acceptance Log (T23) for its four levels: items (accepted by the Product Owner at sprint reviews), requirements, features and releases. Name who accepts each feature and each release.
5. Place the checks that cannot live in the Definition of Done, such as external tests and audits, in the release plan.
6. Keep the Quality & Acceptance Plan (T13) short: the standards, the Definition of Done and its version, and who accepts what.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The Definition of Done is the main quality standard on the Agile track. An item that does not meet it is not done, and is not shown for acceptance.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Write a test strategy covering unit, integration, system, UAT, performance, accessibility and security testing (SAST/DAST, vulnerability scans, penetration test), plus the entry and exit criteria for each.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Definition of Done agreed and logged as a decision
- ✓ Acceptors named for features and releases
- ✓ Acceptance Log set up
- ✓ Test strategy approved (Technical track)

2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement

WHAT IT IS

Decide what to make versus buy, then plan how vendors will be selected, contracted and managed. Write a statement of work (SOW) for each purchase.

WHY IT MATTERS

Vendor lead times and contract terms often decide the schedule. A clear SOW protects scope, quality and payment.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Scope statement, feature list, release plan, budget	02-Planning, workbook	PM
Procurement policies and approved vendor list	Procurement	Procurement

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Statement(s) of Work	Repository: 02-Planning/Procurement	PM (author), Procurement (owner)
Vendor selection decision	Decision Log	Sponsor / Procurement

TEMPLATES

T14 Statement of Work (SOW) Download DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Make-or-buy analysis for each major component.
2. Write the SOW for capacity and outcomes: a team for a number of sprints at a price per sprint, the outcomes expected, and how work is accepted (at sprint reviews, against the Definition of Done).
3. Require the vendor's people to take part in the sprint events, and name any third-party access the work needs, with a needed-by date.
4. Run the selection (RFQ or RFP), score the vendors against agreed criteria and record the decision.
5. Add the vendor's sprints and dependencies to the release plan and the RAID log.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

A price per sprint fits the Agile track: the budget caps the number of sprints, and the Product Owner decides what each sprint builds.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include a vendor security assessment (e.g., SOC 2 Type II report review), data processing agreement, SLAs, data residency and exit/return-of-data terms.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ SOW reviewed by Procurement and Legal
- ✓ Vendor sprints in the release plan

2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate

WHAT IT IS

Check that the release plan, budget, team and backlog agree with each other, and get approval for the three limits, the product goal and the release plan.

WHY IT MATTERS

The parts of a plan can each look fine but contradict each other, for example a schedule that assumes people the budget doesn't fund. Integration catches this before execution starts.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
All planning outputs (Steps 2.1–2.9)	02-Planning, workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Approved plan and the three limits	Repository: 02-Planning; limits in the workbook Setup tab	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)
Planning gate decision	Decision Log	Sponsor

TEMPLATES

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Cross-check: every sprint in the release plan is funded (budget) and staffed (RACI and resource commitments), and the top of the backlog is ready for the first sprint.
2. Confirm the risk reserves cover the top risks.
3. Present the three limits, the product goal, the release plan and the team to the sponsor or steering committee. The question for the gate: are we ready to start sprinting?
4. Freeze the three limits. From now on, a change to a limit goes through change control (Step 4.2); the backlog stays the Product Owner's to change.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The detailed backlog is not approved at the gate. It keeps changing inside the limits.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Get architecture and security design approval at this gate, or plan them into the first sprints.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Three limits approved
- ✓ Gate decision logged
- ✓ Change control active for the limits
- ✓ First sprint ready to plan

CHAPTER 3 · 9 STEPS

Executing

Lead the team and do the work defined in the plan.

Executing is where most of the time and money goes. The PM's job shifts from planning to leading: getting resources in place, keeping the team focused, removing blockers, assuring quality, managing vendors and keeping stakeholders engaged. Executing and Monitoring & Controlling run at the same time, so treat Chapter 4 as the control loop around this chapter.

Exit gate No formal gate. Execution moves into Closing when the final release is accepted (Steps 3.9 and 4.4).

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Manage Project Execution; Manage Quality Assurance; Manage Project Knowledge; Manage Stakeholder Engagement; Manage Communications; Acquire Resources; Lead the Team; Implement Risk Responses (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence

3.3 Assure quality

3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues

3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions

3.8 Refine the backlog

3.9 Release an increment

3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

WHAT IT IS

Confirm the people on the project, onboard them (context, access, tools, working agreement) and build the team's working relationships.

WHY IT MATTERS

A team that understands the goal and has what it needs on day one delivers faster. Missing access and unclear expectations cost weeks.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Resource commitments, RACI	00-Admin, workbook	PM / Functional managers
Onboarding needs (access, tools, training)	Tech Lead, IT	Tech Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Team roster and working agreement	Workbook: Setup tab; 03-Executing	PM
Access and tooling confirmed	Ticket references in the RAID log or Decision Log	Tech Lead / IT

TEMPLATES

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit Download DOCX

T10 RACI Matrix Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold short one-to-ones: experience, goals, how they like to work, how you can support them.
2. Write a team working agreement: hours, response times, tools, decision rules, escalation path.
3. Request access and equipment in advance and track it as a dependency.
4. Revisit the RACI with the full team.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Set up the sprint events (sprint planning, daily scrum, sprint review and retrospective; Appendix B.1). The Developers decide how they organize their work, so write the working agreement with them.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Grant least-privilege access, set up the repositories, branching strategy, CI/CD and environments, and arrange any security awareness or secure-coding training required.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Everyone has access and tools
- ✓ Working agreement published

3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence

WHAT IT IS

Run the sprint cycle that turns the backlog into finished work: sprint planning, the daily scrum, the sprint review and the retrospective, with the Agile PM removing roadblocks and keeping the workbook current.

WHY IT MATTERS

A steady cadence makes progress visible and surfaces blockers while they are still small.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Release plan and Backlog	Workbook: Release Plan and Backlog tabs; backlog tool	PM / PO
Approved plan and RACI	02-Planning	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Increments: finished work that meets the Definition of Done	Repository: 03-Executing or the team's tools	Developers
Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log	Workbook: Sprint Backlog and Sprint Log tabs	Developers (plan), PM (check)
Release Plan statuses kept current	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM

TEMPLATES

T08 Release Plan Download XLSX · T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX · T25 Backlog Download XLSX · T26 Sprint Backlog Download XLSX · T27 Sprint Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T08-Release-Plan-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx; 02-Templates/T26-

Sprint-Backlog.xlsx; 02-Templates/T27-Sprint-Log-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Before each sprint, the Product Owner brings the ordered backlog and the team agrees a one-sentence sprint goal. The Developers choose the items that fit, planning to 60 to 80% of their available hours after meetings and leave, and copy them into the Sprint Backlog (T26), which is rebuilt from empty every sprint. Each item has an owner and any dependency named.
2. Confirm the Definition of Done everyone will use, in its current logged version, and name the top risks for the sprint and who watches them.
3. The Developers hold the daily scrum: 15 minutes, against the sprint goal. It is their planning meeting, not a status report to the Agile PM.
4. Clear blockers within 24–48 hours or escalate them.
5. At the sprint review, the team shows working results. The Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done, and the decision goes in the Acceptance Log (T23). Unfinished and rejected items return to the Backlog.
6. Record the sprint in the Sprint Log (T27): work planned and completed, velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline.
7. Protect the team from unplanned work. New requests go to the Product Owner for the backlog, not straight to the Developers.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

There is no weekly % complete on the Agile track. Progress is the work that meets the Definition of Done, shown in the Sprint Log and the burn-up. Appendix B has the details.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Use pull requests with peer review, automated builds and tests, and track technical debt explicitly as backlog items.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Sprint cycle running
- ✓ Sprint Log updated after every sprint
- ✓ Blockers resolved or escalated

3.3 Assure quality

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the quality activities in the plan (reviews, tests, audits) and improve the process when defects or rework show up.

WHY IT MATTERS

Finding defects early is far cheaper than finding them at acceptance or in production.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Quality & Acceptance Plan	02-Planning	PM / Tech Lead
Deliverables in progress	03-Executing	Developers

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Review and test results, defect log	03-Executing/Quality; defects in the RAID log or test tool	Tech Lead / QA

TEMPLATES

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan Download DOCX

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Run the planned peer reviews and tests and record the results.
2. Run a short quality audit at least once per release: are we following our own plan?
3. Look for patterns in defects and fix the cause, not just the defect.
4. Report the quality metrics in the status report (defects open, pass rate).

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Check every increment against the Definition of Done at the sprint review. Run a pilot or beta release to test with real users before the full launch.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Run SAST/DAST and dependency scanning in the pipeline, fix critical and high vulnerabilities before release, and keep the test evidence for audit.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Planned quality activities completed
- ✓ Defect trends reported

3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the communication plan: status updates, steering meetings, demos and engagement actions. Adjust them as stakeholder needs change.

WHY IT MATTERS

Stakeholders who feel informed and heard support the project. Surprises destroy trust faster than bad news does.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Communication plan, stakeholder register	Workbook: Comms, Stakeholders	PM
Performance data	Workbook: Dashboard	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Status reports and meeting minutes	04-Monitoring/Status; 03-Executing/Meetings	PM
Updated stakeholder register	Workbook: Stakeholders	PM

TEMPLATES

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes Download DOCX

T12 Communication Plan Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx; 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Send status updates after each sprint review, in the same format every time.
2. Deliver bad news early, with a plan and a request for what you need.
3. Follow up on engagement actions for resistant or unaware stakeholders.
4. Ask key stakeholders every month: 'Is this update giving you what you need?'

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Use sprint reviews and demos as the main way to engage stakeholders. Status reports summarize the trend across sprints.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Publish maintenance and release notices, and coordinate with the service desk so support is ready for user questions.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Communications sent on schedule
- ✓ Engagement gaps narrowing

3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues

WHAT IT IS

Carry out the planned risk responses when their triggers occur, and manage issues (problems that have already happened) through to resolution.

WHY IT MATTERS

A risk plan only has value if it is acted on. Issues left open grow and become schedule or budget overruns.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID Log	Workbook: RAID	PM / item owners

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Updated RAID Log (actions, status)	Workbook: RAID	Item owners (update), PM (check)
Escalations	Email or steering pack; recorded in the Decision Log	PM

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Review the Red and Amber items at every sprint review.
2. When a risk occurs, change its type to Issue and start the planned response.
3. Escalate any issue the team can't resolve within its authority: state the problem, its impact, the options, your recommendation and the decision needed by when.
4. Close items when they are resolved and note what worked.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Raise blockers at the daily scrum. Log them in the RAID log only if they last more than a day or put the sprint goal or the forecast at risk.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Route security incidents through the organization's incident response process, not just the project RAID log.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ No Red item without an active response
- ✓ Escalations made within agreed thresholds

3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

WHAT IT IS

Manage vendor performance against the SOW: progress, quality, invoices, issues and relationships.

WHY IT MATTERS

Vendor slips are among the most common causes of delay. Active management catches them early, and documented performance protects you if disputes arise.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
SOWs and contracts	02-Planning/Procurement	Procurement
Vendor status reports and invoices	Vendor	Vendor / PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Vendor performance notes and accepted deliverables	03-Executing/Vendors	PM / Procurement

TEMPLATES

T14 Statement of Work (SOW) Download DOCX

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold regular vendor check-ins linked to the SOW's sprints and outcomes.
2. Approve invoices only against the sprints delivered and the items accepted.
3. Log vendor risks and issues in the RAID log.
4. Escalate contractual issues to Procurement early.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Include vendor staff in all the sprint events. The person the RACI names as accountable for vendors approves invoices against the sprints delivered and the items accepted.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Check vendor access is least-privilege and time-limited, and that the security obligations in the contract are being met.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Vendor work accepted before payment
- ✓ Vendor risks logged

3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions

WHAT IT IS

Record decisions, rationale and know-how as the project goes, so the team and future projects can use them.

WHY IT MATTERS

Decisions that aren't written down get revisited. Knowledge that isn't captured leaves with the people who hold it.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Meetings, workshops, conversations	Calendar, notes	PM / Team

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Decision Log	Workbook: Decisions	PM
Working lessons learned	Workbook: Lessons	PM / Team

TEMPLATES

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx; 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Log every significant decision within 24 hours, including the options considered and why one was chosen.
2. Capture lessons as they happen, not only at the end.
3. Keep documents in the standard repository structure.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Retrospectives produce lessons every sprint. Copy the reusable ones into the Lessons tab.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Keep architecture decision records (ADRs), runbooks and as-built documentation in the code repository or wiki.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Decision Log current
- ✓ Lessons captured during the project

3.8 Refine the backlog

WHAT IT IS

Keep the backlog ordered and ready. The Product Owner adds, removes and reorders items and splits large ones, and works with the Developers to clarify and size the items for the next one or two sprints.

WHY IT MATTERS

Sprint planning only works when the top of the backlog is ready. On an all-agile project, refinement decides what gets built and when, so it runs every sprint, not once at the start.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Backlog	Workbook: Backlog tab	Product Owner
Feedback from the sprint review	Sprint review notes	Product Owner
The forecast	Workbook: Dashboard	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Ordered, sized backlog, ready for the next sprint planning	Workbook: Backlog tab	Product Owner
Updated Requirements Register	Workbook: Requirements tab	Product Owner with the BA

TEMPLATES

T25 Backlog Download XLSX

T06 Requirements Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx; 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Hold refinement regularly through the sprint. Common guidance is to keep it to roughly a tenth of the team's capacity (Appendix B.1).
2. The Product Owner orders the backlog by value, risk and dependency, and can reorder it at any time.
3. Split items that would not fit in one sprint, and write acceptance criteria for the items near the top (Appendix B.3).
4. The Developers size the items for the next one or two sprints.
5. Turn feedback from the sprint review into new items, linked to their requirement. A new requirement goes in the register with an approver and a feature.
6. Check new work against the out-of-scope statement. Anything outside it is not added to the backlog; it needs a change request (Step 4.2).
7. The PM brings the forecast and the risks. If what matters most no longer fits before the end date, the Product Owner moves Should and Could items below the line. The order stays the Product Owner's decision.

TRACK GUIDANCE

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Keep technical debt, security fixes and upgrade work in the backlog, ordered with everything else, not on a separate list.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Top of the backlog ready for the next sprint planning
- ✓ Every item linked to a requirement
- ✓ Nothing outside the out-of-scope statement added without a change request

3.9 Release an increment

WHAT IT IS

Put a set of finished work into users' hands. The Product Owner decides what goes out, the person named to accept the release accepts it, and it is deployed and supported.

WHY IT MATTERS

Releasing early, and more than once, delivers value sooner and tests the product with real users. Each accepted release is firm evidence of progress toward the end date.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Done and accepted items	Workbook: Acceptance tab	Product Owner
Release plan	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM
Readiness checks (Technical track)	T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist	Tech Lead / Security Lead

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Release acceptance	Workbook: Acceptance tab (a Release row)	The named acceptor
Release notes and user communications	Repository: 03-Executing	Product Owner and PM
Release Plan updated	Workbook: Release Plan tab	PM

TEMPLATES

T23 Acceptance Log Download XLSX

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist Download XLSX

T12 Communication Plan Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T22-Go-Live-Readiness-Security-Checklist.xlsx; 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. The Product Owner confirms what is in the release: which features and items.
2. Check that every item in it meets the Definition of Done and has been accepted.
3. The person named to accept the release reviews the evidence and accepts or rejects it. Record the decision as a Release row in the Acceptance Log (T23).
4. Prepare users and support: release notes, training where needed, and a briefing for the help desk (Step 3.4).
5. Release, confirm it works, and mark the release Done in the Release Plan.
6. When a release hands work over to operations, record it on the Acceptance & Transition Sign-off (T21). The final release leads into Step 5.1.

TRACK GUIDANCE

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Complete the go-live readiness checklist (T22) and get CAB approval before each production release, with a tested rollback plan.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Release accepted and recorded
- ✓ Users and support told
- ✓ Release Plan updated

CHAPTER 4 · 5 STEPS

Monitoring & Controlling

Measure progress against the plan, control change, and keep the project on track.

Monitoring & Controlling runs alongside Executing from the first sprint until closing. It compares the work done with the work left and with the three limits, forecasts the finish, controls changes to the limits and makes sure finished work is accepted. The Project Workbook dashboard is designed to support this chapter: update the tabs after every sprint review and the forecast, insights and status numbers update automatically. If the project drifts off track, Appendix E suggests a first response for the most common causes.

Exit gate Ongoing. Phase or release gates use the same data. The project moves to Closing when the final release is accepted.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Monitor and Control Project Performance; Assess and Implement Changes; Monitor and Control Scope; Validate Scope; Monitor and Control Schedule; Monitor and Control Finances; Monitor Stakeholder Engagement; Monitor Communications; Monitor and Control Resourcing; Monitor Risks (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality

4.2 Control changes

4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement

4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables

4.5 Report status and escalate

4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality

WHAT IT IS

After every sprint, compare the work done with the work left and with the end date and budget: velocity, the burn-up, the forecast, and spend against the sprints delivered.

WHY IT MATTERS

Small variances caught early are cheap to fix. Forecasts let the sponsor decide while there are still options.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Sprint Log, budget actuals, RAID log	Workbook	PM, Finance Partner
The three limits	Workbook: Setup tab	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Forecast, performance metrics and RAG status	Workbook: Dashboard	PM

TEMPLATES

T27 Sprint Log Download XLSX

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

T08 Release Plan Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T27-Sprint-Log-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx; 02-Templates/T08-Release-Plan-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. After every sprint review: Sprint Log updated, actuals entered, RAID log reviewed.
2. Check the Dashboard: sprints left at current velocity, the forecast finish against the end date, scope done, spend against the sprints delivered, and open Red risks.
3. Read the burn-up. If the scope line rises faster than the work completed, raise it with the Product Owner.
4. Agree an action when the forecast finish comes within the margin set in Setup, or spend runs ahead of the sprints delivered. The Product Owner adjusts the scope first; a change to a limit goes to Step 4.2.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Earned value is not used on the Agile track. Use velocity to forecast, not to grade the team (Appendix B.5).

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add delivery metrics where they are useful, such as deployment frequency, change failure rate, open critical vulnerabilities and test pass rate.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Dashboard current after every sprint
- ✓ Forecast compared with the end date
- ✓ Variances explained with an action

4.2 Control changes

WHAT IT IS

Decide which changes need approval. Reordering the backlog inside the three limits is not a change. Moving a limit (the end date, the budget or the out-of-scope statement) is, and so is a cost above the Agile PM's authority.

WHY IT MATTERS

Uncontrolled change (scope creep) is one of the main reasons projects miss their targets. Change control doesn't prevent change. It makes sure each change is deliberate.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Change request, where one is needed	Any stakeholder	Requester
The three limits and the Agile PM's authority	Workbook: Setup tab; charter	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Completed Change Request Form (where needed)	04-Monitoring/Changes	Requester (raises), PM (impact analysis)
Change Log with decisions	Workbook: Changes	PM
Updated limits (if approved)	Workbook: Setup tab; charter	PM

TEMPLATES

T24 Change Request Form Download DOCX Example DOCX

T16 Change Request & Change Log Download XLSX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T24-Change-Request-Form-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T16-Change-Request-Change-Log-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Adding, removing or reordering backlog items inside the three limits is the Product Owner's work. It needs no form and no log entry.
2. Log these in the Change Log (T16): any change that moves a limit; any change to the team's capacity that lasts more than one sprint (someone joining, leaving or going part time; a vendor change); any cost above the Agile PM's authority.
3. Raise a Change Request Form (T24) when a limit has to move or a cost is above the Agile PM's authority. Analyze the effect on the limits, the forecast and the risks, recommend approve, reject or defer, and submit it to the approver named in the charter.
4. A capacity change that moves no limit and stays within the Agile PM's authority is logged without a form. Its risk goes in the RAID log, and the burn-up shows the effect.
5. Short absences that sprint planning absorbs are not logged.
6. If a change is approved, update the limits in the charter and the workbook Setup tab, and tell the affected stakeholders and the team.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

On the Agile track, change control protects the three limits, not the backlog.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Changes to production also need CAB approval, which is separate from the project's change control. Include the rollback plan and the risk rating in the CAB request.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every change to a limit has an approved request
- ✓ Longer capacity changes logged
- ✓ The limits reflect approved changes

4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement

WHAT IT IS

Check that risk responses are working, identify new risks, track issues and check that stakeholder engagement is moving in the right direction.

WHY IT MATTERS

Risks and stakeholders change throughout a project, so a register that isn't reviewed soon goes stale.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
RAID log, stakeholder register, Environment Log	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Updated RAID log, stakeholder register and Environment Log	Workbook	PM / item owners

TEMPLATES

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies) Download XLSX

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid Download XLSX

T28 Environment Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx; 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx; 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Review the risks at every sprint review (Red and Amber) and the full list every month.
2. Ask at every sprint review: 'What new risks do we see?'
3. Review the Environment Log (T28) every two weeks. Look up from the project, add new insights about the environment around it and close entries that no longer

matter. Risks do not belong in this log.

4. Check whether each response is reducing the score; if not, change the response.
5. Re-score stakeholder engagement each month and adjust the actions.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Use the sprint retrospective and sprint review to spot new risks and stakeholder concerns.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Track vulnerability findings, audit observations and vendor security issues through to closure.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ RAID log reviewed at every sprint review
- ✓ Environment Log reviewed every two weeks
- ✓ Stakeholder engagement re-scored every month

4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables

WHAT IT IS

Get acceptance of finished work at every level. The Product Owner accepts items at each sprint review, requirements and features are accepted as their items are, and each release is accepted by the person named for it.

WHY IT MATTERS

Formal acceptance is what lets the project close. Without it, deliverables can be disputed after the team has moved on.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Completed and quality-checked deliverables	03-Executing	Developers
Acceptance criteria	Quality & Acceptance Plan; Requirements	PM / PO

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Accepted deliverables and sign-off records	05-Closing/Acceptance	PM (records), Accepting stakeholder (signs)
Acceptance Log, kept current	Workbook: Acceptance tab	PM (records), Accepting stakeholder (accepts)

TEMPLATES

T23 Acceptance Log Download XLSX

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

T06 Requirements Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log-Agile.xlsx; 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register-Agile.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. At each sprint review, the Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done. Record the decision in the Acceptance Log (T23) with the sprint number. An accepted item leaves the Backlog; a rejected or unfinished item returns to it.
2. Check the Requirements Register (T06). It marks a requirement Accepted by itself once its named acceptor has accepted all of its items. If anyone else accepted any of them, the acceptor decides on the whole requirement, and the PM records the decision as a Requirement row.
3. Where someone is named to accept a whole feature, record their decision as a Feature row.
4. Accept each release as in Step 3.9.
5. Log rejected items with the reasons and a plan to fix them.
6. Resolve any “No backlog items” warning in the register: the Product Owner adds an item, so the requirement can be accepted.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Nothing waits for the end. Acceptance happens at every sprint review and at every release.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Get UAT sign-off, security sign-off (penetration test findings fixed or formally accepted) and operational readiness sign-off.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Every finished item accepted or rejected at its sprint review
- ✓ Every release accepted
- ✓ Acceptance Log current

4.5 Report status and escalate

WHAT IT IS

Produce the regular status report and dashboard, run steering meetings and escalate decisions that are above the PM's authority.

WHY IT MATTERS

Leaders can only support what they can see. Consistent reporting builds trust and gets decisions made quickly.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Dashboard metrics	Workbook: Dashboard	PM
RAID log and Decision Log	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Status report after each sprint	04-Monitoring/Status	PM
Steering committee pack (Medium/Large projects)	04-Monitoring/Steering	PM

TEMPLATES

T15 Status Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

T17 Decision Log Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. After each sprint review, update the workbook, then copy the Dashboard numbers into the status report.
2. Lead with the sprint result, the burn-up and the forecast against the end date and the budget.
3. Set the RAG from the forecast. Schedule: Green when the forecast finish is before the end date with room to spare; Amber when it is within the margin set in Setup; Red when it is after the end date. Overall health is the worst of schedule, budget and risk.
4. Put decisions and help needed at the top.
5. Escalate using the format: issue, impact, options, recommendation, decision needed by.
6. If the project is off track, use Appendix E (Recovery plays by cause) to choose a first response before you escalate.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

The sprint review is the best status report. The written report shows the trend across sprints for people who were not there.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Add a short technical health section covering environments, the release pipeline, open critical vulnerabilities and incidents.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Report sent on schedule
- ✓ Escalations have decision dates

CHAPTER 5 · 5 STEPS

Closing

Hand over, learn, and formally finish.

Closing makes sure all the work is finished and accepted, the solution is handed over to the people who will run it, contracts are closed, lessons are captured and the team is released and recognized. Closing applies to each phase or release as well as to the end of the project. Skipping it leaves loose ends: unpaid invoices, unsupported systems, lost knowledge and a team that never got credit.

Exit gate Closure gate: the sponsor confirms the project is complete and approves the closeout report.

Maps to PMBOK® Guide 8th ed. processes: Close Project or Phase (PMBOK Guide 8th ed. process chart).

5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

5.2 Close contracts and finances

5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned

5.4 Write the closeout and impact report

5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

WHAT IT IS

Confirm that every deliverable is accepted, then formally hand the solution over to the business or operations owner with everything they need to run it.

WHY IT MATTERS

A project only creates value when its output is used and supported. Poor handover is a common reason benefits are never realized.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Acceptance records and the Acceptance Log	05-Closing/Acceptance; workbook	PM
Operational requirements (support model, training, documentation)	Operations owner	Operations / Support Owner

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Acceptance & Transition Sign-off	05-Closing	PM (author), Sponsor and Operations owner (sign)

TEMPLATES

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off Download DOCX Example DOCX

T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off-Agile.docx; 02-Templates/T22-Go-Live-Readiness-Security-Checklist.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Check that all acceptance records are complete, using the Acceptance Log (T23).
2. Hand over the documentation, training, access, support contacts and open defects.
3. Agree a hypercare period and its exit criteria (e.g., two weeks with no Severity 1 incidents).
4. Get the transition signed.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Train end users and run change-adoption activities, then track adoption metrics through hypercare.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Complete the go-live readiness checklist, run the cut-over and hypercare, hand over the runbooks and monitoring, and transfer admin access while removing project-only access.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Transition signed
- ✓ Hypercare exit criteria met

5.2 Close contracts and finances

WHAT IT IS

Confirm that vendors have delivered, settle the final invoices, close the purchase orders and the project cost codes, and release any unused reserve.

WHY IT MATTERS

Open contracts and cost codes create financial and legal exposure, and unused budget sitting in the project can’t be used elsewhere.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Contracts, SOWs, invoices	02-Planning/Procurement; Finance	Procurement / Finance Partner
Accepted vendor deliverables	03-Executing/Vendors	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Contract closure records and final financials	05-Closing/Financials; workbook Budget tab	Procurement, Finance Partner

TEMPLATES

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Confirm all vendor deliverables are accepted.
2. Pay the final invoices and close the purchase orders.
3. Record vendor performance for future sourcing decisions.
4. Reconcile the final budget against the baseline and close the cost codes.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Close capacity-based vendor agreements and reconcile them against the sprints actually delivered.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Make sure vendor access has been revoked, data has been returned or destroyed as the contract requires, and licenses are transferred to the operations owner.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ All POs closed
- ✓ Final cost reconciled
- ✓ Vendor access removed

5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned

WHAT IT IS

Hold a structured, blame-free review of what to start, stop and continue, and turn the lessons into concrete recommendations for future projects.

WHY IT MATTERS

Lessons not acted on just get repeated. A good retrospective makes the next project cheaper and less risky.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
Lessons captured during the project	Workbook: Lessons	PM
Performance data (variances, change log, RAID history)	Workbook	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Lessons Learned Register	Workbook: Lessons; shared with the PMO library	PM

TEMPLATES

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register Download XLSX

Template files: 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Invite the core team and key stakeholders, and make it a safe space.
2. Walk through the sprints and releases to refresh memories.
3. Ask: what should we start, stop and continue doing?
4. Turn each lesson into a recommendation with an owner (e.g., update template T08).

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Combine the themes from the sprint retrospectives with the end-of-project review.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include post-incident reviews and deployment metrics, and feed improvements back into engineering standards.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Retrospective held
- ✓ Each lesson has a recommendation and an owner

5.4 Write the closeout and impact report

WHAT IT IS

Summarize what was delivered, how the project performed against its baselines, the benefits achieved, the lessons and the open items. Present the impact to the sponsor and stakeholders.

WHY IT MATTERS

It formally records the project's results, shows the value delivered and gives future teams a reference.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
The three limits and the final actuals	Workbook	PM
Success criteria and benefit measures	Charter; business owner	Sponsor / Business owner
Lessons Learned Register	Workbook: Lessons	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Closeout & Impact Report	05-Closing	PM (author), Sponsor (approver)

TEMPLATES

T20 Closeout & Impact Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Compare the results with the product goal and the three limits: finished by the end date, within the budget, inside the out-of-scope statement. Explain the variances.
2. Show what was delivered release by release, and what was deferred and why.
3. Report results against each success criterion, with data.
4. List open items and their new owners, and the plan for measuring later benefits.
5. Present to the sponsor and get approval to close.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Show the value delivered in increments over the life of the project, not only at the end.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Include final architecture, security posture (residual risks accepted), operational metrics since go-live and the technical debt handed over.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Report approved by the sponsor
- ✓ Benefit measurement plan handed to the business owner

5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

WHAT IT IS

Archive the project records, release the people and resources, update the PMO records and recognize the team’s contribution.

WHY IT MATTERS

Archives support audits and future projects, releasing resources quickly helps the rest of the organization, and recognition builds the goodwill your next project will need.

INPUTS: WHERE TO GET THEM, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE TO GET IT	RESPONSIBLE
All project records	Project repository	PM

OUTPUTS: WHERE THEY ARE KEPT, WHO IS RESPONSIBLE

ITEM	WHERE IT IS KEPT	RESPONSIBLE
Archived repository (read-only)	Organizational records system	PM / PMO
Team release notes and recognition	Email to managers; team event	PM

TEMPLATES

T20 Closeout & Impact Report Download DOCX Example DOCX

Template files: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report-Agile.docx

HOW TO DO IT

1. Clean up and archive the repository using the retention rules.
2. Tell functional managers the release dates and give feedback on each person's contribution.
3. Celebrate: thank the team publicly, share the impact story and recognize individuals.
4. Close the project in the PMO portfolio.

TRACK GUIDANCE

AGILE

Celebrate releases and sprint goals met throughout the project, as well as at the end.

TECHNICAL (IT + SECURITY)

Archive the repositories, decommission temporary environments and confirm that project service accounts and credentials are revoked.

DONE WHEN

- ✓ Archive complete
- ✓ Team released and recognized
- ✓ Project closed in the portfolio

Appendix A. Template library

Every template is an original, editable file with its usage guide built in. Fifteen templates have an Agile version, and this track uses it. Templates marked ‘also in the workbook’ exist both as a standalone file and as a tab in the Agile Project Workbook. Five Word templates (the charter, the status report, the change request form, the closeout report and the acceptance sign-off) also have a filled-in example from Project Beacon on the Agile track, in the 05-Examples folder.

T01 Project Intake & Business Case

Download DOCX

Captures a request in enough detail to decide whether it should become a project.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Complete sections 1–4 with the requester in a 30–45 minute conversation.
2. Quantify the problem: cost of doing nothing, volume affected, risk exposure.
3. List at least two options (including ‘do nothing’) and recommend one.
4. Have the Finance Partner check the cost and benefit numbers before the sponsor sees them.
5. Get a go/no-go decision from the sponsor and record it in section 8.

Used in: 1.1 Capture the request and build the business case

File: 02-Templates/T01-Project-Intake-Business-Case.docx

T02 Project Charter

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

Formally authorizes the project and gives the PM authority to use organizational resources.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write the scope as the product goal, the outcomes and a first ordered feature list.
2. State the three limits: the start and end date, the budget, and the out-of-scope statement. They are the project's baselines.
3. Name the Agile PM and the Product Owner. State the Agile PM's authority in time and money; backlog order is the Product Owner's.
4. Say who is accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and the gates (the detail goes in the RACI, T10).
5. Circulate for comments, then get a recorded sign-off from the sponsor.

Used in: 1.2 Define goals and success criteria, 1.5 Draft and approve the project charter · also in the workbook (tab: Setup)

File: 02-Templates/T02-Project-Charter-Agile.docx

T03 Stakeholder Register & Power/Interest Grid

Download XLSX

Lists everyone affected by or able to affect the project, and plans how to engage each one.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Brainstorm names with the sponsor; ask each stakeholder 'who else should I talk to?'
2. Score Power and Interest 1–5. The grid quadrant is calculated automatically.
3. Set Current vs Desired engagement (Unaware, Resistant, Neutral, Supportive, Leading).
4. Write one concrete engagement action for every gap between current and desired.
5. Review monthly. People change roles and their attitudes change.

Used in: 1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders, 2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: Stakeholders)

File: 02-Templates/T03-Stakeholder-Register-Power-Interest-Grid.xlsx

T04 Delivery Approach & Tailoring Worksheet

Download XLSX

Chooses the track for the project, Agile or Hybrid, decides whether the Technical track applies, and records which playbook steps to scale up or down.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Score each workstream on the eight suitability questions (1 = predictive, 5 = agile).
2. Agile: every workstream averages 3.5 or more, a Product Owner can be named, and the project can work inside three limits. Otherwise Hybrid.
3. Technical: yes if the project changes production systems, data or access, or has security, privacy or regulatory obligations.
4. Pick a size (Small/Medium/Large) using the tailoring table in the playbook.
5. Record every step you will skip or simplify, with the reason, so auditors and successors understand your choices.

Used in: 1.4 Choose the delivery approach and tailor the playbook

File: 02-Templates/T04-Delivery-Approach-Tailoring-Worksheet.xlsx

T05 Kickoff Meeting Kit

Download DOCX

Agenda, talking points and checklist for the project kickoff meeting.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Send the pre-read (charter summary) 48 hours before the meeting.
2. Have the sponsor open the meeting with the ‘why’. It gives the project credibility.
3. Walk through the product goal, the out-of-scope statement, the release plan, the roles and the team’s working agreement.
4. Capture questions in the decision log or RAID log and send notes within 24 hours.

Used in: 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 3.1 Acquire and onboard the team

File: 02-Templates/T05-Kickoff-Meeting-Kit-Agile.docx

T06 Requirements Register

Download XLSX

Captures what the solution must do and how well, as requirements with priority, acceptance criteria, an approver and an acceptor, grouped into features and linked to the backlog items that deliver them.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write each requirement as a user story (‘As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit]’) or as a ‘shall’ statement. The story states the value the requirement promises. The work that builds it is tracked separately, as backlog items in the Backlog (T25).
2. Prioritize with MoSCoW (Must, Should, Could, Won’t this time).
3. Every Must needs testable acceptance criteria and a named approver before it is built.
4. Name one approver and one acceptor for each requirement. The approver approves it before it is built. The acceptor is accountable for accepting it as delivered, and is often the same person.
5. The register works out a delivery status for you: Not started, In backlog, In Sprint N, the count of linked items accepted (for example 2 of 3), Ready for acceptance and Accepted. If the requirement’s acceptor accepted all of its items, or accepted the requirement or its feature, it becomes Accepted by itself. A requirement with no backlog items shows “No backlog items”: add one, so it can be accepted at a sprint review.
6. Give each requirement its feature (ID and name). Several requirements can share a feature. Each backlog item names its requirement and takes the feature from it.

Used in: 2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements, 3.8 Refine the backlog, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables · also in the workbook (tab: Requirements)

File: 02-Templates/T06-Requirements-Register-Agile.xlsx

T07 Scope Statement

Download DOCX

Describes the product vision, the features and the out-of-scope statement, with the constraints and assumptions.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Write it as a product vision: who the product is for, the problem it solves and its main features.
2. Make the out-of-scope statement specific. It is one of the three limits.
3. Do not list deliverables in detail; the feature list and the backlog hold them.
4. Get sign-off from the sponsor and the Product Owner.

Used in: 2.2 Define scope and build the feature list

File: 02-Templates/T07-Scope-Statement-Agile.docx

T08 Release Plan

Download XLSX

Lays out the sprints between the start and end dates, with the releases, milestones and fixed events, and draws them as a Gantt.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one line per sprint, release, milestone or event. Line IDs: S1, S2 for sprints; REL-1 for releases; M-1 for milestones and events.
2. For a sprint, enter the start date; the end date is calculated from the sprint length in Setup unless you type one.
3. Name the release each sprint feeds.
4. Place milestones and fixed events (gates, deadlines, CAB dates) at sprint ends where you can.
5. Keep the status current: Planned, In progress, Done or Cancelled. The end date from Setup is marked on the Gantt.

Used in: 2.3 Build the release plan, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality · also in the workbook (tab: Release Plan)

File: 02-Templates/T08-Release-Plan-Agile.xlsx

T09 Budget & Cost Tracker

Download XLSX

Builds the cost estimate and tracks planned vs actual spend by category.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Estimate bottom-up: labor (hours × rate) and non-labor items.
2. Add a contingency reserve sized to the risk (typically 5–15%) and show it on its own line.
3. Enter actuals monthly from the finance system. Variance and percent spent are calculated for you.
4. Investigate any line more than 10% over its plan.
5. On the Agile track, cost the team per sprint (for example “5 sprints at $18,000”) and add the fixed costs. The approved total is a limit: moving it needs a change request (T24).

Used in: 2.4 Estimate costs and set the budget, 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality, 5.2 Close contracts and finances · also in the workbook (tab: Budget)

File: 02-Templates/T09-Budget-Cost-Tracker.xlsx

T10 RACI Matrix

Download XLSX

Makes clear who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable or decision.

HOW TO USE IT

1. List the deliverables or decisions down the rows and the roles or people across the columns.
2. Exactly one A per row. The check column flags rows with no A or more than one.
3. Keep the number of C entries low. Each extra one slows decisions down.
4. Review the matrix with the team at kickoff and get explicit agreement on it.
5. Use the Agile roles: Sponsor, Agile PM, Product Owner, Scrum Master, Developers, BA, Tech Lead, Security Lead, Finance, Vendor.
6. The ready-made rows name who is accountable for the budget, stakeholders, vendors and each gate. Fill them in for your project; they vary. Keep the rows for backlog order (Product Owner A), delivery toward the end date (Product Owner A, Agile PM R), how the work is done (Developers A) and release readiness (Product Owner A).

Used in: 1.5 Draft and approve the project charter, 2.5 Plan resources, roles and the RACI, 3.1 Acquire and onboard the team · also in the workbook (tab: RACI)

File: 02-Templates/T10-RACI-Matrix-Agile.xlsx

T11 RAID Log (Risks, Assumptions, Issues, Dependencies)

Download XLSX

One register for everything that could, or already does, get in the way of delivery.

HOW TO USE IT

1. A risk is something that might happen. An issue is something that has happened. Move risks to issues when they occur.
2. Score Probability and Impact 1–5. The score (P×I) and RAG rating are calculated for you.
3. Every Red or Amber item needs an owner, a response (avoid, mitigate, transfer, accept) and a due date.
4. Review the top 10 items at every sprint review and close out stale entries.

Used in: 2.6 Plan risk management: identify, analyze and plan responses, 3.3 Assure quality, 3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: RAID)

File: 02-Templates/T11-RAID-Log-Risks-Assumptions-Issues-Dependencies.xlsx

T12 Communication Plan

Download XLSX

Defines who gets what information, how often, in which format and from whom.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Build one row per audience, not per message.
2. Ask stakeholders how they prefer to receive updates. Don’t assume.
3. Assign an owner to every communication and put recurring ones on the calendar right away.
4. Review the plan after each gate and whenever stakeholders change.

Used in: 2.7 Plan communications and stakeholder engagement, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate, 3.9 Release an increment · also in the workbook (tab: Comms)

File: 02-Templates/T12-Communication-Plan.xlsx

T13 Quality & Acceptance Plan

Download DOCX

States the quality standards, the Definition of Done, the checks outside it, and who accepts items, requirements, features and releases.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Keep it short: the standards, the Definition of Done and its version, and who accepts items, requirements, features and releases.
2. Build checks into the Definition of Done where you can, instead of saving them for the end.
3. Log the Definition of Done and every later change in the Decision Log (T17).
4. Technical track: attach the test strategy (unit, integration, UAT, performance, security).

Used in: 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 3.3 Assure quality

File: 02-Templates/T13-Quality-Acceptance-Plan-Agile.docx

T14 Statement of Work (SOW)

Download DOCX

Describes the capacity a vendor provides, the outcomes expected, how work is accepted and how it is paid for.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Contract for capacity and outcomes: a team for a number of sprints at a price per sprint.
2. Accept work at sprint reviews against the Definition of Done, and pay against the sprints delivered.
3. Require the vendor's people in the sprint events, and name any third-party access needed, with a needed-by date.
4. Include requirements for security, data handling and confidentiality.
5. Have Procurement and Legal review it before it goes to vendors.

Used in: 2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement, 3.6 Manage vendors and contracts

File: 02-Templates/T14-Statement-of-Work-SOW-Agile.docx

T15 Status Report

Download DOCX

Example DOCX

A one-page update after each sprint: overall RAG, the sprint result, the forecast, top risks and decisions needed.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Lead with the sprint result, the burn-up and the forecast against the end date and the budget.
2. Set the overall RAG as the Dashboard does: the worst of schedule, budget and risk.
3. List decisions or help needed with an owner and a date. This is the most-read section.
4. Use the same format every sprint so readers can compare reports at a glance. The workbook dashboard supplies the numbers.

Used in: 2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate, 4.5 Report status and escalate · also in the workbook (tab: Dashboard)

File: 02-Templates/T15-Status-Report-Agile.docx

T16 Change Request & Change Log

Download XLSX

Records the changes that move one of the three limits, change the team's capacity for more than one sprint, or cost more than the Agile PM may approve, with their impact and the decision.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Reordering, adding or removing backlog items inside the limits is not a change. Do not log it.
2. Log any change that moves a limit, changes capacity for more than one sprint, or costs more than the Agile PM's authority. Choose what it changes: End date, Budget, Out-of-scope boundary, Team capacity, or Cost only.
3. "Change request needed?" is calculated: Yes when a limit moves or the cost is above the Agile PM's approval limit in Setup. Then raise a Change Request Form (T24).
4. Note the requirements or releases the change affects.
5. If approved, update the limits and mark "Limits updated?". Rejected changes stay in the log.

Used in: 4.2 Control changes · also in the workbook (tab: Changes)

File: 02-Templates/T16-Change-Request-Change-Log-Agile.xlsx

T17 Decision Log

Download XLSX

Records significant decisions, the options considered, who decided and why.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Log any decision that would be expensive to reverse or that someone may question later.
2. Record the options considered and the reasoning, not just the outcome.
3. Log the Definition of Done when it is agreed and again whenever it changes (version, date, what changed and why), so the team can see how the standard moved.
4. Link related change requests or RAID items.

Used in: 1.1 Capture the request and build the business case, 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 2.9 Plan sourcing and procurement, 2.10 Integrate the plan and pass the planning gate, 3.5 Implement risk responses and resolve issues, 3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions, 4.2 Control changes, 4.5 Report status and escalate · also in the workbook (tab: Decisions)

File: 02-Templates/T17-Decision-Log.xlsx

T18 Meeting Agenda & Minutes

Download DOCX

A standard agenda and minutes format that turns meetings into decisions and actions.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Send the agenda at least 24 hours ahead with the desired outcome of each item.
2. Record decisions, actions (owner and date) and new risks. Skip the play-by-play.
3. Send the minutes within 24 hours and move the actions into the workbook.

Used in: 1.6 Hold the initiation gate and kickoff, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 3.4 Engage stakeholders and communicate

File: 02-Templates/T18-Meeting-Agenda-Minutes.docx

T19 Retrospective & Lessons Learned Register

Download XLSX

Captures what to start, stop and continue, and turns lessons into actions for future projects.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Run short retrospectives after each sprint or phase, not only at the end of the project.
2. Use the Start/Stop/Continue framing so the discussion stays safe and constructive.
3. Convert each lesson into a recommendation with an owner (e.g., update a template or standard).
4. Share the register with the PMO or a lessons library.

Used in: 3.7 Manage project knowledge and decisions, 5.3 Run the retrospective and capture lessons learned · also in the workbook (tab: Lessons)

File: 02-Templates/T19-Retrospective-Lessons-Learned-Register.xlsx

T20 Closeout & Impact Report

Download DOCX Example DOCX

Summarizes what was delivered, results against the product goal and the three limits, benefits, lessons and open items.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Compare the results with the product goal and the three limits.
2. Show what each release delivered, and what was deferred and why.
3. Report benefits against the success criteria in the charter, with data.
4. List open items and who now owns them.
5. Use the impact section (executive summary, results, what worked, next steps) as the sponsor briefing.

Used in: 5.4 Write the closeout and impact report, 5.5 Archive, release the team and celebrate

File: 02-Templates/T20-Closeout-Impact-Report-Agile.docx

T21 Acceptance & Transition Sign-off

Download DOCX Example DOCX

Records formal acceptance of deliverables and the handover to operations or the business owner.

HOW TO USE IT

1. List the accepted items, requirements and the release with their evidence. Copy them from the Acceptance Log (T23).
2. Confirm the operations owner has the training, documentation, access and support model they need.
3. Agree a warranty or hypercare period and its exit criteria.
4. Have the sponsor and the receiving owner sign it.
5. On the Agile track you can use it for each release that hands work over to operations, as well as at the end.

Used in: 3.6 Manage vendors and contracts, 3.9 Release an increment, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables, 5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

File: 02-Templates/T21-Acceptance-Transition-Sign-off-Agile.docx

T22 Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist

Download XLSX

Technical track: confirms that release, security, data, rollback and support criteria are met before production changes.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Start the checklist at least two weeks before the planned go-live.
2. Each item needs an owner, a status and evidence (a link or document).
3. Any ‘No’ on a critical item blocks go-live unless the sponsor and Security Lead record an exception.
4. Attach the completed checklist to the CAB request.

Used in: 3.9 Release an increment, 5.1 Confirm final acceptance and transition to operations

File: 02-Templates/T22-Go-Live-Readiness-Security-Checklist.xlsx

T23 Acceptance Log

Download XLSX

Records every acceptance decision during the project, for backlog items, requirements, features and releases: the evidence, who accepted it, when, and the decision.

HOW TO USE IT

1. One row per decision. The PM keeps the log; the acceptor decides. Levels: Item (shown at a sprint review), Requirement (the named acceptor’s decision on the whole requirement, when someone else accepted some of its items), Feature (a decision on a whole feature, where someone is named for it) and Release.
2. For an item, record its ID, title, requirement and sprint. For a feature or a release, record its ID (F-01, REL-1). For a requirement, record its ID.
3. Record the date and the evidence (test result, demo, inspection, document review).
4. Record the decision (Accepted or Rejected), who accepted it and the date. An item with unmet conditions is not accepted: record it as Rejected, with the work still needed. A rejected item returns to the Backlog, and the next decision on it is a new row.
5. At each release that hands over, and at the end, use the log to complete the Acceptance & Transition Sign-off (T21).

Used in: 2.8 Plan quality and acceptance, 3.9 Release an increment, 4.4 Validate scope and accept deliverables · also in the workbook (tab: Acceptance)

File: 02-Templates/T23-Acceptance-Log-Agile.xlsx

T24 Change Request Form

Download DOCX Example DOCX

A one-page form for a change that moves one of the three limits, or costs more than the Agile PM may approve: its impact, the recommendation and the approval.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Anyone can raise a change. Describe the change, why it is needed and what happens if it is not made.
2. Tick why a request is needed: a limit moves, or the cost is above the Agile PM’s authority.
3. The PM completes the impact analysis for the end date, budget, out-of-scope boundary, team capacity, forecast, risk and quality.
4. Recommend approve, reject or defer, and submit the form to the approver or change board named in the charter. The form must say who it is submitted to.
5. Record the decision and the date. If approved, update the limits, tell the affected stakeholders and add a row to the Change Log (T16).
6. Technical track: if production is affected, attach the rollback plan and the risk rating for the CAB, which approves separately.

Used in: 4.2 Control changes

File: 02-Templates/T24-Change-Request-Form-Agile.docx

T25 Backlog

Download XLSX

Lists the open work to be built in sprints, ranked and sized, with each item linked to the requirement it delivers. It changes constantly: items leave for a sprint, return, and are re-ranked.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Break each requirement (T06) down into the work that delivers it: a feature, task, fix, spike (a short, time-boxed investigation) or technical debt item. Link every item to its requirement. An item such as a bug fix may have no new requirement. The requirement says what is promised; the item says how it will be built.
2. Rank the items. The Product Owner owns the order and can re-rank at any time. The top of the list is detailed and ready; the bottom can stay rough.
3. Give each item a size in the team's own unit.
4. At sprint planning, pull the items for the next sprint into the Sprint Backlog (T26). Items that are not finished, or that are rejected at the sprint review, return here and are ranked again.
5. An accepted item leaves the Backlog. Its record is the Acceptance Log (T23).

Used in: 2.1 Elicit and analyze requirements, 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 3.8 Refine the backlog · also in the workbook (tab: Backlog)

File: 02-Templates/T25-Backlog.xlsx

T26 Sprint Backlog

Download XLSX

Lists the backlog items the team commits to in the current sprint, with owners and progress. It is rebuilt from an empty sheet at every sprint planning session and holds nothing needed later.

HOW TO USE IT

1. At sprint planning, clear the sheet. Write the sprint number and the one-sentence sprint goal.
2. Pull items from the Backlog (T25) in rank order until the sprint is full, planning to 60 to 80% of the team's available time.
3. Give each item an owner and note any dependency.
4. Update the status as the sprint runs. Mark an item done only when it meets the Definition of Done.
5. At the sprint review, copy the totals into the Sprint Log (T27), record the Product Owner's decisions in the Acceptance Log (T23) and return unfinished or rejected items to the Backlog. Then the sheet is ready to clear for the next sprint.

Used in: 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence · also in the workbook (tab: Sprint Backlog)

File: 02-Templates/T26-Sprint-Backlog.xlsx

T27 Sprint Log

Download XLSX

Records the plan and result of each sprint, including sprints that deliver nothing: work planned and completed, velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Add one row per sprint at sprint planning: the sprint’s Line ID in the Release Plan (S1, S2), from which the dates are looked up, the goal and the work planned.
2. At the sprint review, copy in the work completed from the Sprint Backlog totals. Count only items that meet the Definition of Done. Acceptance is a separate decision, recorded in the Acceptance Log (T23). A sprint that completes nothing still gets a row.
3. Velocity and the running average are calculated, and the Dashboard draws the burn-up against total scope.
4. List the carry-over items (their IDs), the top risk for the sprint, any decisions needed and the headline from the retrospective, with a link to the Lessons Learned Register (T19).
5. Plan from the trend, not from one sprint: a falling velocity with stable scope is an early warning.

Used in: 3.2 Direct the work and run the delivery cadence, 4.1 Track performance: schedule, cost, scope and quality · also in the workbook (tab: Sprint Log)

File: 02-Templates/T27-Sprint-Log-Agile.xlsx

T28 Environment Log

Download XLSX

Keeps the PM looking up from the project to the wider environment in which it is meant to deliver value. It records insights to be aware of. It is not a place to store risks.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Every few weeks, step back from the project and look at the environment around it: the organization, the market, regulation, technology, and other teams' work.
2. Log an insight when you notice it: what you learned, where it came from, a short category in your own words (for example, a reorganization, a strategy shift, a funding change, market or economic conditions, regulation, weather, or another team's initiative) and when it takes effect.
3. Note why it matters to the value the project is meant to deliver, so that you stay aware of it.
4. Keep it light. An entry needs no project resources to watch, and it does not belong in the RAID log unless it becomes a risk. Risks are managed through the risk process, not here.
5. Review the log every two weeks and close entries that no longer matter.

Used in: 1.3 Identify and analyze stakeholders, 4.3 Monitor risks, issues and stakeholder engagement · also in the workbook (tab: Environment)

File: 02-Templates/T28-Environment-Log.xlsx

Appendix B. Agile quick reference

On the Agile track the whole project runs in sprints, inside its three limits: the end date, the budget and the out-of-scope statement. This appendix covers what an Agile Project Manager needs to run it. It is not a course in Scrum or any other framework; the sources at the end go deeper.

B.1 The sprint cycle

A sprint is a fixed-length period, usually two to four weeks (Project Beacon uses two), in which the team turns the highest-priority backlog items into finished, usable work. The fixed length gives the team a rhythm, and it gives you a dependable unit for release planning and the forecast. Five regular events keep the cycle running. The time limits below grow with sprint length: the first figure is for a two-week sprint and the second for a four-week sprint. For a three-week sprint, use the middle.

1. Sprint planning. The Product Owner brings the top-priority items. The team decides how much it can finish and agrees a sprint goal: one sentence on why this sprint matters. Output: the sprint goal and the sprint backlog (T26). Time limit: 4 hours (two-week sprint), 8 hours (four-week sprint).
2. Daily scrum (daily stand-up). A 15-minute check where the team compares progress with the sprint goal and names blockers. It is for the team, not a status report to the Agile PM.
3. Backlog refinement. Ongoing work in which the Product Owner and team clarify, split and size upcoming items so they are ready for planning. Common guidance is to keep it to roughly a tenth of team capacity.
4. Sprint review. At the end of the sprint the team shows working results to the Product Owner and stakeholders. The Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done, against its acceptance criteria, and records the decision in the Acceptance Log (T23). Unfinished and rejected items return to the backlog, and feedback goes into it. It doubles as your stakeholder demo and a checkpoint for the forecast. Afterwards, record the sprint's result in the Sprint Log (T27). Time limit: 2 hours (two-week sprint), 4 hours (four-week sprint).
5. Sprint retrospective. The team looks at how it worked, picks one or two changes to try next sprint, and records any lessons for the Lessons Learned Register (T19). Time limit: 1.5 hours (two-week sprint), 3 hours (four-week sprint).

B.2 Who does what

Use this rule of thumb: the Product Owner owns why, what and when, through the order of the backlog; the Developers own how; and the Agile PM owns the conditions that let them deliver on time.

- Product Owner: develops and communicates the product goal, orders the backlog, explains each item, and accepts or rejects finished work.
- Developers: decide how many items fit in a sprint and how to build them. Nobody outside the team assigns work inside a sprint.
- Scrum Master: accountable for the team's effectiveness; coaches the way of working and helps remove impediments. Often the Agile PM. Avoid combining either role with the Product Owner, because it removes the check between "what we want" and "what we can afford".
- Agile Project Manager: enables the team, removes roadblocks, watches the forecast against the end date, and owns risks and reporting, plus the budget, stakeholders, vendors and gates where the RACI says so. Does not reorder the backlog or assign sprint work.
- Sponsor: sets the three limits, approves changes to them, and accepts releases where the RACI says so.

B.3 Writing stories and backlog items

Write each requirement that users will see as a short user story: "As a [type of user], I need [capability] so that [benefit]." The story describes the value the requirement promises. Add acceptance criteria that say how anyone can tell the requirement is met. Check each story against six qualities, which agile teams remember as INVEST: it can be built Independently, it is open to Negotiation, it delivers Value, the team can Estimate it, it is Small enough to deliver in a sprint or two, and it is Testable.

Large stories are called epics. Split an epic into smaller stories before its work enters the backlog.

Requirements and backlog items are different things. A requirement is a specification: what the solution must do or achieve, with acceptance criteria and a named approver. Its user story describes the value it promises. It lives in the Requirements Register (T06). A backlog item is the work that delivers that promise, a piece of work or a capability to build in a sprint, and it lives in the Backlog (T25). Break each requirement down into one or more items and link each item to its requirement. One requirement may need several items, and an item such as a bug fix or technical debt may trace to no new requirement.

How an item moves. Every item starts as a requirement. The requirement, with its user story, goes in the Requirements Register (T06) and names its approver, its acceptor and its feature. The requirement is then broken down into backlog items, the work that delivers it, and the items go in the Backlog (T25). The Product Owner ranks the Backlog and can re-rank it at any time. At sprint planning the team pulls items into the Sprint Backlog (T26), which holds one sprint only and is rebuilt from empty each time. At the sprint review, the Product Owner accepts or rejects each item that meets the Definition of Done, and the decision goes in the Acceptance Log (T23) with the sprint

number. An accepted item leaves the Backlog. A rejected item, or one that was not finished, returns to the Backlog and is ranked again, so one item can pass through several sprints. A requirement is accepted when every item that delivers it is accepted. If the requirement's named acceptor accepted all of its items, the Requirements Register marks it Accepted by itself. If different people accepted different items, the acceptor decides on the whole requirement and the PM records that decision in the Acceptance Log, so that one named person is accountable for the whole. The Requirements Register shows each requirement's status, from Not started to Accepted, with who accepted it and when, taken from the Backlog, the Sprint Backlog and the Acceptance Log.

Acceptance criteria and the Definition of Done are different. Acceptance criteria belong to one story or requirement ("a volunteer can cancel a shift up to 24 hours before it starts"). The Definition of Done is a checklist that applies to every item (reviewed, tested, documented). Meeting it is the team's own test of finished work. Acceptance is a separate decision by the Product Owner or approver. The Quality & Acceptance Plan (T13) records the Definition of Done, and the Decision Log (T17) records each change to it.

B.4 Story mapping

A story map arranges the backlog as a picture of the user's journey instead of a flat list.

1. Write the main activities a user performs, left to right, in the order they happen. This row is the backbone.
2. Under each activity, stack the stories that support it, with the most important at the top.
3. Draw horizontal lines across the map to slice it into releases. The top slice is the thinnest version that is still useful to a real user.

A map shows the whole product before the parts, gives the Product Owner and sponsor a shared picture, and makes it easy to explain what waits for a later release. Project Beacon's volunteer side looks like this:

```
Sign up      Find a shift    Book or cancel   Do the shift   Log hours       Get certificate
-------      ------------    --------------   ------------   ---------       ---------------
Account      Browse open     Book a shift     (offline)      Enter hours     Download PDF
with MFA     shifts          Cancel up to                    after a shift   with total hours
                             24h before
             Coordinators: create recurring shifts with capacity limits
- - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - - -
Release 1 (MVP pilot, Mar 27): everything above this line (Sprints 1 to 3)
                                                                  Text reminders
                                                                  (deferred)
```

The donor side (recurring gifts, nightly CRM sync) forms a second backbone, planned for Sprints 4 and 5.

B.5 Planning releases against the end date

1. Size the backlog. Give each item a relative size (story points or small, medium, large). Relative sizing is quicker and, over many items, about as reliable as hour estimates.
2. Learn the team's velocity. Velocity is the amount of work a team finishes in one sprint, counted in whatever unit the team estimates in. If the team sizes work in story points, velocity is the story points completed per sprint. Count only items that are fully done and meet the Definition of Done: a nearly finished item adds nothing. Record it in the Sprint Log (T27). Before any sprint has finished, plan with a range and replace it with real numbers after the second or third sprint.
3. Work out what fits. Sprints available multiplied by the velocity range gives the scope the team can deliver by the date. Plan people at about 60 to 80% of their available project time, after subtracting meetings and leave (see the capacity guidance in the planning steps).
4. Place releases at sprint ends, and keep a buffer between the forecast and the end date. A release tied to a sprint review has real evidence behind it.
5. Re-forecast every sprint. When the date and the budget are fixed, scope is the variable. Use the MoSCoW lines (Must, Should, Could) to decide what moves when the forecast slips. Forecast the finish: the scope remaining divided by the average velocity gives the sprints left. The Dashboard shows the forecast finish next to the end date.

Use a burn-up chart to show progress. It plots two lines against time: total scope and work completed. The gap between them is the work left. When scope grows, the scope line rises and everyone can see it, which is why a burn-up is better than a burn-down for stakeholder reporting.

Velocity has two good uses. The team's recent average tells you how much work to plan into coming sprints, and the trend over several sprints shows whether the team is speeding up or is blocked. Treat a change as a prompt to ask why, not as a grade: a rising number can simply mean the estimates are growing. Do not compare velocity across teams, because each team's estimates are relative to its own work. Do not make it a target either, because pushing it up tends to inflate estimates instead of finishing more. A falling velocity alongside a stable scope line is an early warning that the end date is at risk.

B.6 Common problems on an all-agile project

Watch for these common problems.

- Fixing the scope before anyone has sized the backlog.
- The Agile PM reordering the backlog, which is the Product Owner's job.

- Raising a change request for ordinary reprioritization. Changing the backlog inside the three limits is normal; only a change to a limit goes through change control.
- Letting the backlog grow past the out-of-scope statement. A new idea outside it needs a change request, or waits for a later project.
- Skipping the retrospective when the end date is close. That is when it pays back most.
- Marking items done that do not meet the Definition of Done. The forecast then looks healthier than the product is.
- Reporting velocity without scope. Show both, as a burn-up.

B.7 Project Beacon on the Agile track

This is the same project as the Hybrid example, retold as if it had run on the Agile track. Neither version is the right one: they show the same work under two approaches.

Sprint 2 (February 23 to March 6, 2026) delivered shift booking. Its goal, in one sentence: “A volunteer can see open shifts and book or cancel one.” The sprint backlog held the items for R-02 (book and cancel) and R-03 (recurring shifts with capacity limits), and the password reset item carried over from Sprint 1. Late in the sprint the work was about 80% complete, and the sprint review moved from March 6 to March 10. The same sprint carried the spike to test the CRM’s API limits (risk R-002). In that week’s status report, Marcus Lee, the Agile Project Manager, reported the forecast: at an average velocity of 27 points, the 89 points remaining needed four more sprints, finishing about May 1, ahead of the June 1 go-live and inside the June 26 grant deadline. He linked the sprint evidence to that forecast, rather than reporting task activity.

B.8 Where to learn more

These sources are also listed in Appendix D.

- Schwaber, K. and Sutherland, J. (2020). The Scrum Guide. https://scrumguides.org
- Patton, J. (2014). User Story Mapping. O’Reilly Media.
- Wake, B. (2003). INVEST in Good Stories, and SMART Tasks. https://xp123.com/invest-in-good-stories-and-smart-tasks/
- Project Management Institute and Agile Alliance (2017). Agile Practice Guide.
- Beck, K. et al. (2001). Manifesto for Agile Software Development. https://agilemanifesto.org

Appendix C. Glossary

Short definitions in plain words, listed alphabetically. Each term appears in the playbook, the templates, the example workbook or Appendix B.

Acceptance criteria
The specific conditions an item must meet before the person accepting it agrees it is done.

Acceptance Log
A running record of every acceptance decision for backlog items, deliverables and requirements: the evidence, who accepted or approved it, the date, the sprint for an item, and the decision (Accepted or Rejected).

Activity list
The steps inside each work package, with owners, dates and progress. In the workbook it drives each work package's % complete.

Agile Project Manager (Agile PM)
The project manager on the Agile track. See the roles section for the definition.

Assumption
Something believed true for planning purposes but not yet confirmed. Record it in the RAID log so someone checks.

Backlog (product backlog)
The ordered list of everything that might be built, kept by the Product Owner. The top is detailed and ready; the bottom is rough.

Backlog item
A piece of work that delivers a requirement and is built in a sprint, such as a feature, task, fix or spike. Each item is linked to its requirement. An accepted item leaves the backlog; a rejected or unfinished one returns to it.

Baseline
The approved version of the scope, schedule or budget that you measure progress against. It changes only through change control.

Benefits realization
Confirming, after delivery, that the expected benefits actually appeared, with data.

Burn-up chart

A chart of total scope and completed work over time. The gap between the lines is the work remaining.

Business case

The argument for doing a project: the problem, the options, the costs and benefits, and the recommendation.

CAB (Change Advisory Board)

The group that approves changes to production systems before they go live.

CCB (Change Control Board)

The group that approves changes to a project's baseline.

Change request

A formal proposal to change the scope, schedule or budget, with its impact analysis and a decision.

Charter

The document that authorizes the project and gives the PM authority to use resources.

Contingency reserve

Money or time set aside for identified risks. Draw on it only through the agreed process.

CPI (Cost Performance Index)

Earned value divided by actual cost. Below 1.0 means the work is costing more than planned; above 1.0 means less.

Critical path

The longest chain of dependent tasks. A delay to any task on it delays the finish date.

Cut-over

The moment when users and data move from the old way of working to the new one.

DAST (dynamic application security testing)

Testing a running application from the outside for security weaknesses.

Definition of Done

A checklist that every backlog item must meet before the team calls it finished. It is not the same as acceptance, which is a separate decision by the Product Owner or approver.

Deliverable

Something the project produces that someone can inspect and accept.

Dependency

A relationship in which one task, or an outside event, must happen before another can start or finish.

Developers

The people on a Scrum team who build, test and deliver each increment.

Earned value

The budgeted value of the work actually completed. Used to compare progress with spending (see CPI and SPI).

Environment Log

A short record of insights about the wider environment in which the project is meant to deliver value, such as organizational changes, funding cycles, market or regulatory conditions, and other teams' initiatives. It keeps the PM aware of the bigger picture. It is not a risk register.

Epic

A large user story that must be split into smaller stories before its work can be built.

Feature

A capability users will recognize, such as "Shift booking". On the Agile track, features group requirements in the Requirements Register and the Acceptance Log.

Float (slack)

How long a task can slip without delaying the finish date. Tasks on the critical path have none.

Forecast (sprints left)

The scope remaining at the last sprint review divided by the average velocity, rounded up. It gives the forecast finish date.

Gantt chart

A bar chart of tasks against time, showing start, finish and dependencies.

Gate

A planned decision point where a sponsor or committee decides whether the project may continue to the next stage.

Hybrid delivery

Mixing plan-driven management (fixed milestones, budget, approvals) with iterative delivery (sprints and a backlog).

Hypercare
A short period after go-live when the project team stays close to fix problems quickly before handing over fully.

Increment
The working result of a sprint, usable and meeting the Definition of Done.

Issue
A problem that has already happened and needs action. A risk becomes an issue when it occurs.

Lessons learned
What the team learned that could improve future work, written as recommendations with an owner.

MFA (multi-factor authentication)
Signing in with two or more proofs of identity, such as a password and a code from a phone.

Milestone
A significant point in the plan, such as an approval or a delivery. It takes no time itself.

MoSCoW
A priority scheme: Must, Should, Could, Won’t this time.

MVP (minimum viable product)
The smallest version of a product that real users can use and give feedback on.

OKR (objectives and key results)
A goal-setting method that pairs an ambition with measurable results.

Out-of-scope statement
What the project will not include, however the backlog changes. One of the three limits on the Agile track.

PMO (project management office)
A group that sets project standards, supports project managers and often tracks the portfolio.

Product goal
The future state of the product that the backlog serves. The Product Owner is accountable for it.

Product Owner
The person who owns the backlog, decides its order and accepts or rejects finished work.

RACI

A matrix showing who is Responsible, Accountable, Consulted and Informed for each deliverable or decision.

RAG (red, amber, green)

A traffic-light rating of status.

RAID log

One register of Risks, Assumptions, Issues and Dependencies.

Release

A set of finished work made available to users.

Release plan

The sprints between the start and end dates, with the releases, milestones and fixed events.

Requirement

A specification of what the solution must do or achieve, with acceptance criteria and a named approver. Its user story describes the value it promises; backlog items are the work that delivers it.

Retrospective

A team meeting to review how the work went and agree improvements.

Risk

An uncertain event that, if it happens, affects the project. Score it by probability and impact.

Rolling-wave planning

Planning near-term work in detail and later work at a higher level, adding detail as it gets closer.

RPO (recovery point objective)

How much recent data, measured in time, an organization can afford to lose after an outage.

RTO (recovery time objective)

How long a service can be down before the harm becomes unacceptable.

SAST (static application security testing)

Analyzing source code for security weaknesses without running it.

Scope creep

Growth in what the project must deliver without matching changes to time, budget or approval.

Scrum Master

The person who coaches a team in its way of working and removes blockers.

SLA (service level agreement)

A written commitment to a level of service, such as response times.

SOW (statement of work)

The document describing what a vendor will do, by when, to what standard and for what payment.

SPI (Schedule Performance Index)

Earned value divided by planned value. Below 1.0 means behind schedule.

Sprint

A fixed-length period in which a team completes a chosen set of backlog items.

Sprint backlog

The backlog items the team commits to finish in one sprint, chosen at sprint planning. It is rebuilt from empty for each sprint.

Sprint goal

One sentence that states the purpose of a sprint.

Sprint Log

A record of each sprint's goal, plan and result, including sprints that deliver nothing: work planned and completed, velocity, carry-over items and the retrospective headline.

SSO (single sign-on)

One login that gives access to several systems.

Stakeholder

Anyone affected by the project or able to affect it.

Story map

A picture of the user's journey with stories stacked beneath each step, sliced into releases.

Technical debt

The future cost of shortcuts taken in design or code. It is tracked as backlog work.

Threat model

A structured review of how a system could be attacked and which controls address each threat.

Three limits

The start and end date, the budget and the out-of-scope statement: the baselines on the Agile track.

Traceability

Links from each requirement to the backlog items or deliverables and the tests that cover it.

UAT (user acceptance testing)

Testing by the people who will use the product, to confirm it meets their needs.

User story

A short description of a need from the user's point of view: who, what and why.

Velocity

The amount of work a team finishes in one sprint, counted in the unit the team estimates in (such as story points), and counting only fully finished items. Teams use their recent average to plan how much to take on, and watch the trend for signs that they are speeding up or are blocked.

WBS (work breakdown structure)

A breakdown of the project scope into smaller deliverables and work packages.

WBS dictionary

A companion to the WBS that describes each work package: what it delivers, its acceptance criteria and who accepts it.

WCAG (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines)

The W3C standard for making web content usable by people with disabilities.

Work package

The lowest level of the WBS: a piece of work small enough to assign, estimate and track.

Appendix D. Sources & further reading

These works were consulted for ideas, coverage and background. No affiliation with, or endorsement by, their authors, publishers, PMI or Google is implied. Names are used only to identify the sources.

1. Project Management Institute (2025). The PMBOK® Guide – Eighth Edition. Five focus areas, seven performance domains and 40 processes used for the step structure. https://www.pmi.org/standards/pmbok
2. Project Management Institute. PMI launches the PMBOK® Guide – Eighth Edition (announcement). Used to check the counts of principles, performance domains, focus areas and processes. https://www.projectmanagement.com/articles/1134510/pmi-launches-the-pmbok--guide---eighth-edition
3. PMBOK 8th Edition Process Chart (Andrew Ramdayal, PMP exam prep). Process-to-phase mapping used in each chapter's 'Maps to' line.

4. Ricardo Viana Vargas. PMBOK Guide process-flow charts and infographics. Consulted for how the processes fit together; nothing is reproduced. https://ricardo-vargas.com/
5. Technical Institute of America (TIA). PMP exam-prep course materials. Consulted for coverage; nothing is reproduced. https://www.tiaexams.com/
6. Project Management Institute. PMP Examination Content Outline. Consulted for coverage; nothing is reproduced.
7. PM Study Circle. What is new in the PMBOK Guide 8th Edition (released in 2025; 6 principles, 7 domains, 40 processes). https://pmstudycircle.com/pmbok-guide-8th-edition/
8. Google Project Management Professional Certificate (Coursera): Initiation, Planning, Execution and Closing guiding questions. Used as a reference for good practice only; no course material is reproduced. https://www.coursera.org/professional-certificates/google-project-management
9. Creative Commons. Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International (CC BY-NC-SA 4.0). https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/
10. W3C. Web Content Accessibility Guidelines (WCAG) 2.2, referenced in non-functional requirements. https://www.w3.org/TR/WCAG22/
11. Microsoft. The STRIDE threat model, referenced in Step 2.6 (Technical track). https://learn.microsoft.com/en-us/azure/security/develop/threat-modeling-tool-threats
12. Project Management Institute. Qualitative risk assessment (PMI Learning Library). Background for the five-level probability and impact scale in Step 2.6. https://www.pmi.org/learning/library/qualitative-risk-assessment-cheaper-faster-3188
13. Scrum Alliance. Capacity planning for a Scrum team. Background for the 60 to 80% capacity guidance in Steps 2.5 and 3.2. https://resources.scrumalliance.org/Article/capacity-planning-scrum-team
14. Tero Parviainen (2016). A Dash of Queueing Theory. Background for the point that waiting grows sharply as utilization nears 100%. https://teropa.info/blog/2016/04/02/a-dash-of-queueing-theory
15. Schwaber, K. and Sutherland, J. (2020). The Scrum Guide. Background for Appendix B (sprint events, roles and the Definition of Done) and for the Agile track’s roles (Product Owner, Scrum Master, Developers). https://scrumguides.org
16. Patton, J. (2014). User Story Mapping. O’Reilly Media. Background for story mapping in Appendix B.
17. Wake, B. (2003). INVEST in Good Stories, and SMART Tasks. Background for writing backlog items in Appendix B. https://xp123.com/invest-in-good-stories-and-smart-tasks/
18. Project Management Institute and Agile Alliance (2017). Agile Practice Guide. Background for the Hybrid and Agile tracks.
19. Beck, K. et al. (2001). Manifesto for Agile Software Development. https://agilemanifesto.org

Appendix E. Recovery plays by cause

Most projects drift off track at some point. This appendix lists common causes, the signs that point to each one, and a first response. It adds no new steps: each response points back to the steps and templates that already cover it.

E.1 Start with a health check

Before choosing a response, find out where the project really stands.

1. Limits. Compare the forecast finish with the end date, the spend with the budget, and the backlog with the out-of-scope statement.
2. Risks and issues. List the open Red and Amber items and who owns each one.
3. Sponsor. Is the sponsor engaged, and do they know the real position?
4. Goals. Do the original goals and success criteria still hold?

Then choose one of three paths: recover inside the three limits, move a limit through change control (Step 4.2), or escalate to the sponsor for a decision (Step 4.5). Never move a limit silently. A changed limit needs a logged decision.

E.2 Scope creep

- Signs: work from outside the out-of-scope statement is being added to the backlog; the scope line on the burn-up keeps rising; the forecast finish moves later every sprint.
- First response: check each new request against the out-of-scope statement. Inside it, the Product Owner decides where it goes in the backlog, and something of lower value may have to move below the line. Outside it, raise a change request (T24), log it (T16) and show its effect on the end date, the budget and the forecast. Offer the sponsor three choices: approve it and move a limit, trade it for something already planned, or defer it to a later project. Remind everyone of the out-of-scope statement in the charter.
- Where to look: Steps 1.5, 3.8 and 4.2.

E.3 Missed deadlines

- Signs: the forecast finish is later than the end date, or moves later every sprint; sprint goals are missed; items carry over sprint after sprint; velocity falls while scope stays the same.
- First response: re-forecast from the running average velocity and the scope remaining, not from the original plan. Find what is slowing the team: blockers, items that are too large, unplanned work or carry-over. Then offer options: the Product Owner moves Should and Could items below the line, add capacity only where it will help (new people need time before they are useful), or move the end date through change control.

- Where to look: Steps 2.3, 3.8, 4.1 and 4.5.

E.4 Changing requirements

- Signs: stories are rewritten again and again; people disagree about what done means; work is redone after review.
- First response: separate changes inside the three limits (reordering the backlog, which needs no change request) from changes that cross the out-of-scope statement or move the end date or the budget (which do). Confirm who approves each requirement and who accepts it, and review the acceptance criteria with that person. If the Definition of Done changes, log it as a decision.
- Where to look: Steps 2.1, 2.8, 3.8, 4.2 and 4.4.

E.5 Over budget

- Signs: spend is running ahead of the sprints delivered; the reserve is falling faster than the scope; the budget will not fund the sprints the forecast needs.
- First response: compare the spend with the sprints delivered, and the sprints left at current velocity with the sprints the budget still funds. Then offer options: the Product Owner reduces the scope so the work fits the funded sprints, find savings, use the reserve as the plan allows, or ask the sponsor to move the budget limit through change control.
- Where to look: Steps 2.4 and 4.1.

Earned value is not used on the Agile track. The cost to finish is the cost of one sprint times the sprints left, plus the fixed costs still to come. Compare it with what is left of the budget.

E.6 Nobody knows what is left

- Signs: the backlog is out of date or not sized; the scope remaining in the Sprint Log is a guess; different people give different answers.
- First response: with the Product Owner, refine the backlog: remove what is no longer wanted, size what is left, and check the done items against the Acceptance Log. Record the real scope remaining in the Sprint Log at the next sprint review, so the forecast can be trusted again.
- Where to look: Steps 3.2, 3.8, 4.1 and 4.4.

E.7 An overloaded or short-staffed team

- Signs: people are planned beyond 60 to 80% of their available time; overtime is routine; mistakes and rework are rising.
- First response: re-plan to a realistic load. Move work, add people or cut scope. Cross-train so that no task depends on one person. Do not ask the same people to catch up by working longer.
- Where to look: Steps 2.5, 3.1 and 3.2.

E.8 Quality or security failures

- Signs: defects or critical vulnerabilities are rising; tests fail late; items marked done do not meet the Definition of Done.
- First response: stop starting new work until the cause is understood. Fix and re-test, and check that the Definition of Done is being applied. Do not go live with a critical No on the readiness checklist unless the sponsor and the Security Lead record an exception.
- Where to look: Steps 3.3 and 4.4, and the go-live checklist (T22).

E.9 A vendor slipping

- Signs: a vendor misses a date, gives no firm date, or delivers work that fails acceptance.
- First response: get a firm date in writing and check what the contract (SOW) says about dates and remedies. Keep the team moving: the Product Owner reorders the backlog so other work goes first, build against a stub or sandbox, or ask for a partial delivery. Log the risk or issue, and escalate with options if the forecast finish will move past the end date.
- Where to look: Steps 3.6 and 4.3.

E.10 A sponsor who is not engaged

- Signs: decisions wait for weeks; meetings are missed; the sponsor hears about problems late.
- First response: find out why. Talk to the sponsor directly, not by email. Ask what is getting in the way: time, priorities, confidence in the project, or unclear role expectations.
- Where to look: Steps 1.3, 4.3 and 4.5.

The same play applies to a Product Owner who is not available. Without them the backlog stalls, questions wait and nothing is accepted. Agree the time the role needs, or ask the sponsor to name someone who can give it (Step 1.3).

Appendix F. License & credits

© 2026 James Pearson. This playbook, its templates and the Project Workbooks are licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License.

- **You may** share and adapt the material.
- **Attribution**: you must credit James Pearson, link to the license and say whether you made changes.
- **NonCommercial**: you may not use it for commercial purposes (e.g., selling it or including it in paid training or consulting deliverables) without written permission.
- **ShareAlike**: if you adapt it, you must share your version under the same license.

Using this at work. Using the templates and workbook to run your own projects, including at work, is fine. Selling or repackaging them, including them in paid training, or handing them to clients as a product needs my written permission.

How to credit: “Project Manager in a Box” by James Pearson, licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0 (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-sa/4.0/).

For commercial licensing, contact the author.

Find me online: LinkedIn · GitHub · Portfolio repository

How this was made. Written and assembled by James Pearson with help from an AI assistant (Anthropic’s Claude). The AI drafted much of the text. I defined the scope and structure, chose what to include, reviewed and edited the content, and tested the templates and workbook. This project is independent and is not affiliated with or endorsed by Anthropic.

No warranty. This playbook, its templates and the workbook are a starting point, provided as is and without warranty of any kind. They are not legal, financial, security or professional advice. Check requirements with your own organization before relying on them, especially the Go-Live Readiness & Security Checklist (T22).

PMI, PMBOK and PMP are registered marks of the Project Management Institute, Inc.
Project Beacon, Northside Food Collective and all people in the examples are fictional.